



Hindustan Times

US puts Iran trade partners on notice

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WASHINGTON: US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent announced a new round of sanctions aimed at Iran on Monday and warned every country that does business with the Islamic Republic to sever those financial ties or face retaliation from Washington.
The new warnings to further cut off Iran from the rest of the world economy were issued after President Donald Trump pledged last week to unleash an "economic D-Day" against Tehran as the administration struggles to find an off-ramp after nearly six months of war.
"We're level-setting with every country to tell them our expectations. We know who they are. They know who they are," Bessent told a news conference on the sidelines of the U.S. Treasury actions falls upon them, they will have no one to blame but themselves."
Washington has promised the new sanctions would put



"We are going to hold everyone accountable, and this is economic asphyxiation of this regime... Any entity that facilitates money laundering on behalf of Iran will be removed from the US dollar system. The clock just started ticking."
— **SCOTT BESSENT, US TREASURY SECRETARY**
even more pressure on an Iranian economy already battered by previous sanctions and a U.S. naval blockade. But the announcement Monday provided little detail and did not name which countries could face secondary sanctions. China, Turkey and the United Arab Emirates are Iran's largest trade partners.
Bessent said Trump has been "making phone calls to world leaders with specific requests to cease their interactions" with Iran and has already seen

CENTRE LIFTS WHEAT EXPORT RESTRICTIONS

Pallavi Singhal
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NEW DELHI: The government on Monday lifted restrictions on wheat exports, allowing traders to ship the grain and flour freely after months of quota-based exports, as comfortable government stocks eased food-security concerns. However, traders said the move may not immediately translate into large shipments because Indian wheat remains too costly for most overseas markets. ➔P2

GLUT TO SQUEEZE: SUGAR SHORTAGE MAY DEEPEN

Pallavi Singhal
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NEW DELHI: India entered the sugar season expecting a surplus, only to see production estimates repeatedly cut. Prices surged and exports that were initially allowed, were halted. With stocks heading towards a two-decade low and next year's crop facing weather risks, a supply crunch may deepen. ➔P2

'NORMAL PRACTICE FOR VISITS': OFFICIALS ON U.S. ENVOY'S 'NO QUESTIONS' REMARK

NEW DELHI: The government on Monday responded to US ambassador Sergio Gorr's remarks about the external affairs ministry (EAM) seeking a "no questions" media interaction between PM Narendra Modi and President Donald Trump by saying this is the "standard practice" for PM's visit. Gor said while participating in a media conclave on Sunday that EAM had asked that there be no "full press conference" when Modi and Trump met on the margins of the G7 Summit in June. ➔P5

CRPF MAN INJURED AS FRESH GUNFIGHT, ARSON HIT MANIPUR

Thomas Ngangom
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IMPHAL: A CRPF jawan was injured during a gunfight between security forces and unidentified armed individuals in the Taphou area of Manipur's Senapati district on Monday, hours after two houses belonging to different communities were set ablaze by an unknown group of people in the area, officials aware of the matter said. ➔P6

1998 MASSACRE OF 23 KASHMIRI PANDITS TO BE PROBED AGAIN

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SRINAGAR: The Jammu & Kashmir's State Investigation Agency (SIA) has restarted probe into the killing of 23 Kashmiri Pandits by terrorists in the Wandhama village of Ganderbal district in 1998, officials said. They added that the case was reopened as part of a wider push to pursue long-pending cases of targeted killings during the "peak of militancy". ➔P7

3 infants killed as ventilator blast sparks fire in hospital

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NAGPUR: Three infants were killed after a fire broke out in the newborn care unit of a government hospital in Amravati district in Maharashtra early on Monday, prompting the state government to order an investigation.
The fire broke out around 3:30am on the third floor of the District Women's Hospital, which houses three Special Newborn Care Units (SNCUs) — specialised wards near the labour room that treat unwell newborns. Thirty-nine infants were admitted across the three units at the time of the incident.
"It appears that the fire



started inside a ventilator... Unfortunately, three babies died," Amravati police commissioner Rakesh Ola said.
Thirty-six infants were rescued from the units and six of them, who were critically ill, were later shifted to nearby private super-specialty hospitals for treatment, officials said. ➔P7

K'taka's draft SIR rolls released, over 27% voters face cut

Abhishek Jha and Naheed Ataulla
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NEW DELHI/BENGALURU: At least 10.8 million names, or 19.5% of the total electors, have been omitted in the draft electoral roll for Karnataka after the completion of the enumeration phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), marking the second highest deletion among the big states after 21.6% removal in Telangana at the draft stage.
On Monday, the Election Commission on India (ECI) published Karnataka's draft electoral roll, which has 44.6 million electors, 10.8 million (19.5%) less than the 55.4 million names on the rolls before the SIR exercise began on June 20 this year.
In the draft roll published on Monday, 2.3 million people are

IN DRAFT ROLL, 2.3 MILLION PEOPLE ARE NOT MAPPED TO THE 2002 ELECTORAL ROLL AND ANOTHER 2 MILLION HAVE DISCREPANCIES

not mapped to the 2002 electoral roll and another 2 million have discrepancies, making around 4.4 million people included in the draft roll vulnerable to deletion in the final stage.
If all these 4.4 million people stand removed in the final roll, the total deletion in Karnataka from pre-SIR roll to final roll would stand at 15.2 million or 27.4%. ➔P5

MP/MLA NOD FOR AID: HC ASKS DELHI GOVT FOR AFFIDAVIT

Shruti Kakkar
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NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Monday asked the Delhi government to file an affidavit in 10 days explaining the objective behind requiring women availing Delhi Lakshmi Yojana to obtain an endorsement letter from an MP or MLA to be eligible for the aid.

KAILASH COLONY: 71-YR-OLD WOMAN RUN OVER BY SUV

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NEW DELHI: A 71-year-old woman died and her husband was injured after a speeding SUV hit several vehicles before crashing into the couple near Kailash Colony metro station in south Delhi late on Sunday. Police said they arrested the driver, Tapan Ahir (59). ➔P5

{ HT IMPACT } IN CAPITAL

SC censures MCD, ASI over monuments' state



August 10: HT reported on the poor upkeep of Lodi-era tombs in Zamrudpur

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday pulled up the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) for exhibiting "total callousness" and suppressing facts about the condition of the Capital's heritage monuments.
The court's strong observations came after it was apprised of an August 10 Hindustan Times report on the sorry state of Lodi-era tombs in Zamrudpur, which have been heavily encroached upon.

Govt to bundle bigger, smaller airports in privatisation proposal

NEW DELHI: The government is planning to privatise 11 airports in the country by grouping them into five bundles with the aim of subsidising smaller airports with the earnings of larger ones to make them sustainable in the long term.
The five bundled airports are: Amritsar and Kangra-Gaggal; Varanasi, Gaya and Kushinagar; Bhubaneswar and Hubballi; Raipur and Aurangabad; and Tiruchirappalli and Tirupati, according to the minutes of an August 4 meeting of the Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC). ➔P2

TN JUNKS PLAN FOR AIRPORT AT PARANDUR

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister and TVK president C Joseph Vijay on Monday announced the scrapping of the proposed Parandur airport project, sparking a political row in the state. The main opposition party, DMK, criticised the decision and staged a walkout from the state assembly. ➔P5

NUMBER THEORY

PART 2

Rethinking Viksit Bharat: The wider neglect of manufacturing

By Roshan Kishore

The first part of this series flagged manufacturing as the key challenge in boosting India's economic gap vis-à-vis China. It also highlighted that the problem lies in a lag in per-worker productivity and a growing tendency to prioritise trade rather than domestic value added. What really explains this problem despite incremental reforms since 1991? The problem is often seen as an issue within the sector rather than relative to other sectors. This does not help. The data is clear.



Scan the QR code to read Part 1: Why manufacturing is India's Achilles Heel

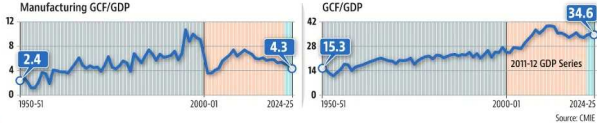


1 India does not have an investment problem; it has an investment-in-manufacturing problem

That investment kickstarts future growth is a well-accepted fact in economics. China is the best example of this in the recent past. In fact, many economists accuse China of suppressing domestic consumption to boost investment. India has been battling a laggard private investment climate for the last decade or so. While this story is well known, a sectoral reading of the situation provides a crucial insight. India has not done badly regarding the overall investment rate in the economy.

This shows in the share of Gross Capital Formation (GCF) in GDP. However, what has become a bigger problem is the marginalization of manufacturing in the overall investment being made in the Indian economy. Comparing overall GCF and manufacturing GCF in GDP shows this clearly. While a long-term comparison of these two variables requires clubbing data from various GDP series, which often entail breaks from previous trends, it is the only way to do this comparison.

Decoupling of manufacturing with India's investment story (Numbers in percent)



2 Manufacturing's supply-side crisis of investment shows in big industry's falling demand in bank credit

Sector-wise allocation of bank credit data supports the supply-side story of falling manufacturing investment in the Indian economy. In 2007-08, the earliest period for which this data is available, bank credit to large industry was 12.6% of GDP. This increased consistently to reach about 18% by the early 2010s. It fell steadily thereafter, reaching lower than its 2007-08 levels by 2019-20 and further to 8.6% by 2025-26. Credit to MSME industries,

however, does not show a similar trend and has largely remained steady. The falling credit demand from large industry has led to a situation where housing credit (only a part of personal credit) has already overtaken it and even agricultural credit has come pretty close to overtaking it. That Indians are borrowing more to build houses and almost as much to grow crops as they are for factories speaks volumes about capital allocation in India.

The fall and fall of large industry credit (Chart shows total outstanding credit as share of GDP. (Numbers in percent))



3 Manufacturing did not make India's post-reform growth story

If manufacturing has been losing investment momentum, as shown here, even when India's domestic manufacturing value added has been fading relative to imports and the merchandise trade deficit has been rising, what explains the absence of policy urgency to solve the problem? The answer is found in its absence in India's growth turnaround post-reforms.

A basic comparison of sector-wise drivers of growth from 1966-67 to 2025-26 in the 2011-12 GDP series proves this. Manufacturing's growth contribution, despite the supposed deregulatory momentum from reforms, has largely been flat. India's real growth driver has been the financial services, real estate and professional services sector.

Manufacturing's contribution to GVA growth has barely changed in India

Chart shows percentage share in GVA growth in a given period

	1966-67 to 1990-91	1990-91 to 2007-08	2007-08 to 2025-26
Financial services, real estate and professional services	18	21.7	26.9
Trade, hotels, transport, communication and broadcasting services	13.1	20	19.3
Manufacturing	16.5	18	17.2
Public administration, defense and other services	11.4	10.2	14.4
Agriculture, forestry and fishing	28.6	12.3	10.3
Construction	6.7	9.9	9.2
Electricity, gas, water supply and other utility services	2.8	2.3	2.2
Mining and quarrying	6.3	3.5	0.6

Calculations using 2011-12 GDP series. 1966-67 earliest period for which sector-wise GVA data is available. Post-reform period has been classified into two to account for 2008 Global Financial Crisis

Source: CME

4 Skewed growth in finance was balanced with welfare to manage political peace

Finance and professional services generated not just growth but also white-collar jobs and higher tax revenues. This fiscal cushion funded by finance and professional services, allowed the provision of palliatives to manage economic pain stemming from the lack of a mass employment-generating economic transformation. Before the recent proliferation of cash transfer schemes to win elections came the large-scale expansion of India's welfare programmes, which is seen in things such as rapidly increasing transfers on centrally sponsored schemes etc. The end result of such policies is best seen in a ratio which captures India's basic political economy dilemma: rural living standards

versus urban. A comparison of average Monthly Per Capita Expenditure (MPCE) in rural and urban areas since 1993-94 shows that the rural-urban ratio fell from 0.61 in 1993-94 to 0.52 in 2003-04, the last survey round before the shock defeat of the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government in the 2004 elections, famously referred to as an indictment of the India Shining campaign. The trend reversed in the subsequent rounds, with the rural-urban MPCE ratio reaching 0.59 in 2023-24. Herein lies India's core political economy dilemma: it managed political peace by using resources from an elite-services-driven growth but now risks losing the larger economic



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FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



School buses and a car caught in a waterlogged road at Subhash Chowk in Gurugram on Monday.

Rain hobbles NCR again with flooding, jams rerun

Aaditya Khatwani
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NEW DELHI: An hours-long surprise spell of rain flooded large parts of Delhi on Monday, with the state government's efforts to prevent waterlogging coming up short once again this monsoon, even as the showers also pummeled neighbouring cities in the National Capital Region (NCR) and brought everyday life to a standstill.

Delhi's base weather station at Safdarjung received 34.6mm of rain between 8.30am and 5.30pm, but several neighbourhoods got far more. Janakpuri

was the wettest part of the city with 72.5mm, followed by Aya Nagar (69.1mm), Chhatrapur (61.5mm), Palam (58.2mm), Delhi Ridge (45.2mm) and Lodhi Road (41.7mm).

The rain brought traffic to a standstill throughout the day, especially affecting students on their way back from school. Visuals of children wading through mucky waist-deep water in Delhi went viral on social media, while school buses broke down on flooded roads in Gurugram, forcing some students to walk while others waited for hours without food or water.

The weather forced airlines

to divert 15 flights.

The winds, of speeds of up to 55km/h, also uprooted nine trees in eight neighbourhoods, according to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD).

The situation came weeks after PWD minister Parvesh Verma said more than 95% of drains in the city had been desilted ahead of the monsoon. Verma did not respond to repeated requests for comment on Monday.

A Delhi public works department official, who asked not to be named, said the number of waterlogging points in the city "have reduced from 194 to 65 due to the government's efforts"

and said the situation was being continuously monitored.

"However, the recent intense rainfall has resulted in temporary water accumulation at some vulnerable locations, including stretches under the jurisdiction of different agencies. Such instances are being addressed on priority... PWD has also undertaken additional desilting and capacity-restoration works at vulnerable stretches, including locations that had not been desilted for several years due to inter-agency and access-related issues. Temporary pumping arrangements are being

continued on →

CJP calls Sep 5 march, says promises not kept

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NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Monday announced a peaceful protest march in Delhi on September 5 from India Gate to the Delhi police headquarters, alleging that the Centre failed to honour commitments made to young protesters when the stir at Jantar Mantar was called off last month.

Among the prominent issues the CJP will raise are assurances given on July 25 on the withdrawal of first information reports registered against protesters. Despite notifications given by the home departments of at least four states — including Delhi — that no action would be taken against protesters in those FIRs, they have not yet been

School student protests spur corrective steps across states

NEW DELHI: Governments of at least four states have started taking some corrective steps following protests by school students in Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra this month.

The protests, which gained momentum after the

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), on August 15 launched a national School Think Karo Abhiyan (Reform Schools Campaign) to expose poor infrastructure and teaching facilities in schools, were mostly about inadequate staffing, poor midday meals, and bad infrastructure. →P6

withdrawn.

September 5 is marked as Teachers Day in India, dovetailing with the CJP's current focus on government schools.

The 2.5-km march will see the families of National Eligibility

cum Entrance Test (NET) aspirants who died by suicide and victims of alleged police brutality take part. Students, youth organisations and young citizens from across the country have

continued on →

STALIN APPROACHES HC CHALLENGING HIS ELECTION LOSS FROM KOLATHUR

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BENGALURU: DMK president and former Tamil Nadu chief minister MK Stalin on Monday filed a petition in the Madras High Court, challenging his defeat to TVK's VS Babu from the Kolathur seat in the recently held state elections.

Stalin alleged malfunctioning of electronic voting machines and irregularities in the functioning of VVPAT machines. →P5

US proposes new \$103k H-IB visa application fee

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WASHINGTON: In a move that could dent legal immigration prospects for thousands of Indian professionals, the US government has proposed a new \$103,265 application fee on H-IB visas that could apply to international students and workers hired within the country.

The proposal by the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) comes just as the earlier \$100,000 H-IB visa fee — which was announced by Donald Trump as a presidential proclamation in September 2025 and subsequently halted by a US

DHS CLARIFIED THAT THE NEW FEE WILL APPLY ONLY TO CAP-SUBJECT H-IB APPLICATIONS

court in June this year — is set to expire on September 21.

The Trump administration has justified the new fee — which is expected to effectively replace the earlier \$100,000 fee — as necessary to recover the administrative costs of managing America's legal immigration system. DHS clarified that the new fee will apply only to cap-subject H-IB visa applications. →P11



Vladimir Putin, S Jaishankar

PUTIN ASSURES INDIA OF ENERGY SUPPLIES IN MEET WITH JAISHANKAR

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: Russian President Vladimir Putin on Monday assured India of supplies of energy and fertilisers amid disruptions caused by the West Asia conflict, even as external affairs minister S Jaishankar highlighted the need to address the growing imbalance in two-way trade that has soared to \$50 billion. The Russian leader and Jaishankar met in Moscow and discussed a wide-range of issues. →P2

USE TRIAL IN ABSENTIA FOR FUGITIVES HIDING ABROAD: SHAH AT SECURITY BRASS MEET

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NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Monday directed the country's security and intelligence leadership to take strict measures against infiltration as officers discussed the detection and deportation of illegal immigrants, a policy framework to combat cybercrime and proxy warfare by Pakistan. Shah also asked the officers to use the "trial in absentia" option for fugitives hiding in foreign jurisdictions. →P5

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[MY INDIA] FILED BY ABHISHEK

SC to take up plea on rebel TMC MPs



The Supreme Court will hear on Tuesday a petition filed by TMC general secretary and MP Abhishek Banerjee seeking an expeditious decision by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on disqualification petitions against 20 rebel TMC MPs. A bench, comprising CJ Surya Kant and justices Jyoti Basu, Bagchi and V Mohana, is scheduled to hear the plea on August 25. Banerjee has invoked Article 32 of the Constitution to challenge the alleged delay in deciding disqualification petitions against the MPs, who have broken away from the TMC and sought recognition as a separate group in the Lok Sabha. **HTC**

[SPORT] AFTER LOSS TO ARGENTINA

India out of hockey WC semi-final race



India's men's hockey team failed to overcome the pressure of conceding an early goal and saw its hopes of reaching the World Cup semi-finals end with a 3-5 loss to Argentina here on Monday. India needed to win by at least three goals to advance, but conceded twice in the opening six minutes and struggled to recover. Poor passing, frequent loss of possession and a leak defence were their problems. With this defeat, India remained fourth in the pool and will now play for the seventh place. **HTC**

[WORLD] EL NINO WREAKS HAVOC

Ocean temperatures hit new high, eclipse Mar 2024 record



Scientists have recorded the highest temperature ever measured in the world's oceans, as climate change combines with a powerful El Niño in the tropical Pacific. The global average sea-surface temperature hit a record 21.7°C on August 22, according to Europe's Earth observation agency Copernicus, which has been tracking the metric since 1979. The previous record of 21.6°C was measured in March 2024. "As ocean temperatures continue to rise, the risks to marine ecosystems and coastal communities also increase," said Samantha Burgess of Copernicus. **BLOOMBERG**

[SPORT] IND VS SL 2ND TEST

Jaiswal, Fernando fined 25% match fee



India opener Yashasvi Jaiswal and Sri Lanka seamer Asitha Fernando were on Monday fined 25% of their match fee for an on-field altercation on day one of the second test in Colombo. The players were involved in a confrontation after Fernando dismissed Jaiswal in the 17th over of India's first innings. Jaiswal walked towards Fernando and the two exchanged words, following which Fernando moved his head towards Jaiswal. In response, Jaiswal leant in, resulting in their heads making contact. **HTC**

[BUSINESS] OFFER FOR SALE

India to sell up to 6% stake in Hind Copper



The government will sell up to 6% stake in Hindustan Copper Ltd (HCL) through an Offer for Sale (OFS) at a floor price of ₹514 a share. The floor price is at a 10.38% discount over Monday's closing share price of Hindustan Copper on the BSE. In a post on X, Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) secretary Anurish Chawla said the Indian government offers to divest 3% equity in HCL through the OFS, with an option to divest an additional 3% (green shoe option) in case of oversubscription. Shares of Hindustan Copper settled at ₹573.55, up 0.17%, on the BSE on Monday. **PTI**

EAM flags trade gap; Putin assures energy supplies

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: Russian President Vladimir Putin on Monday assured India of supplies of energy and fertilisers amid disruptions caused by the West Asia conflict, even as external affairs minister S Jaishankar highlighted the need to address the growing imbalance in two-way trade that has soared to \$50 billion.

Putin's expected meetings with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the margins of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in Kyrgyzstan this month and at the Brics Summit in New Delhi in September were discussed during a meeting between the Russian leader and Jaishankar in Moscow. Jaishankar said that the SCO Summit and also hopes that you will have the opportunity to come to the Brics Summit and host this annual summit. Jaishankar was quoted as saying by state-run TASS news agency. He also handed over a personal message from Modi to Putin. While co-chairing the IRIGTC meeting with Russia's first deputy prime minister Denis Manturov, Jaishankar pointed out that a more than four-fold increase in bilateral trade in goods — from \$13 billion in 2025-22 to nearly \$60 billion in 2025-26 — had been "accompanied by a significant widening of the trade imbalance" from \$6.6 billion to more than \$50 billion. "Addressing this imbalance is today one of our foremost priorities. Progress on market access, removal of tariff and non-tariff barriers, strengthening payment mechanisms and stronger business engagement will be critical for addressing this imbalance and achieving our shared objective of \$100 billion in bilateral trade by 2030," Jaishankar said at Modi's home.

Putin will attend the Brics Summit in Moscow on Monday.

'WE'RE INCREASING FERTILISER SUPPLIES AND ARE READY TO DO SO FURTHER,' PUTIN SAID DURING A MEETING WITH JAISHANKAR

Jaishankar said at the start of the meeting. Jaishankar proposed focusing on implementation, stronger business engagement and identifying new areas for economic cooperation. Manturov said Rosatom's role in building the Kudankulam nuclear plant could provide a basis for expanding nuclear cooperation, including "new power generation facilities in India" and localisation of equipment and nuclear fuel production. The prototype of a high-speed electric train jointly produced by India and Russia will be assembled by the end of the year, after which serial production is expected to begin, Manturov announced at the meeting. "Within this framework, the flagship project in transport engineering — the development and production of the Vande Bharat electric trains — is systematically developing," he said. Manturov also prioritised energy security, including oil, petroleum products and coal supplies, as well as joint investments in hydrocarbon production and processing. Russia is among India's top two energy suppliers. Russian energy minister Sergei Shmatko described India as a key partner for the development of the energy sector, while deputy prime minister Alexander Novak noted that Moscow is interested in Indian investments in the Russian oil and gas sector and developing a distribution network involving Russian companies in India.

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Britain to open classified missile tech for Ukraine

UK on Monday announced that it will allow defence giant MBDA to share information on British-made components of SCALP missile with Ukraine amid the Russian invasion

BEYOND SUPPLY OF WEAPONS
Kyiv and its allies want to set up a Ukrainian production line for the Franco-British SCALP air-launched cruise missile, known as the Storm Shadow in the UK, by the end of the year, potentially giving Ukraine greater control over its supply. The declassification of information on British-made components of the missile signals a deeper willingness by Ukraine's allies to share sensitive military technology and help Kyiv build more of its own weapons.



Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelenskyy and Britain's Rishi Sunak in Kyiv on Monday.

SCALP: A BOOST ON THE BATTLEFIELD

1,300kg	550km	400kg
Missile weight	Missile range	High-explosive warhead it can carry

The SCALP is a long-range, deep-strike cruise missile designed to destroy pre-planned, hardened targets. Ukraine has used imported versions against targets inside Russia. It can be launched from Su-24 and Mirage 2000 fighter jets and uses terrain-following navigation, GPS and infrared targeting to strike bunkers and command centres while attempting to evade air defences.

The missile also played a key role in Operation Sindoor, when the Indian Air Force (IAF) used it to target terrorist infrastructure.

A VULNERABLE ARSENAL
The technology transfer is unlikely to immediately help Ukraine. It has been relying on US supplies of the Patriots, but its stockpiles are running low due to the war in Iran. The Trump administration has also rebuffed a UK air Nimble bid to buy Tomahawk cruise missile.

MOSCOW WARNS OF ESCALATION
Russia condemned UK's move as a "provocation" and adding "fuel to the fire" and hindering peace efforts. Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Russia was gathering information to locate missile-production sites and destroy them.

Sugar surplus: How India went from surplus to shortage

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NEW DELHI: Buying a packet of sugar in any of the major metros today will set you back by roughly 40% more than a fortnight ago. The reason: A severe supply crunch. This has prompted the government to fortify sugar stores at the onset of the festive season. The government has also begun to import sugar from the US and other countries.

India went from a possible glut, to a serious dearth of sugar in a year. At the beginning of this sugar season (October 1, 2025; it ends on September 30, 2026), the government and the industry prepared for a surplus. Sugar production was expected to rise sharply, diversion to ethanol was expected to be lower, and mills were pressing for permission to export more sugar to foreign markets and to cane farmers from piling up.

Industry body Indian Sugar and Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA), expected sugar output at 34.90 million tonnes (MT) in its first preliminary estimate released in July 2025 for the 2025-26 season. This represented a 18.2% year-on-year increase from 29.6 MT the year before. This was reiterated at a joint conference in September. Based on the estimate, the government allowed the industry to export sugar earlier in the season. This was starkly different from the year before. In the 2024-25 season, the government had allowed 1 million tonnes of exports only in January 2025, whereas for the current season it approved an initial 1.5 million tonnes in November 2025, soon after the season began. It allowed

export of another 500,000 tonnes in February. But by May, projections changed and the policy took a U-turn. The government in May banned sugar exports to September 30, citing the need to serve domestic supplies. By July, it was tightening controls on mills and dealers, and in August it kept the ban. Prices then touched a record of ₹4,800-4,980 per 100kg in the first week of August. Prices then touched a record of ₹5,350 per 100kg, August 18. A day later, ex-mill prices of sugar in Uttar Pradesh which had been rising since late June, touched ₹4,800-4,980 per 100kg. In the first week of August, prices touched a record of ₹5,350 per 100kg, August 18. A day later, ex-mill prices of sugar in Uttar Pradesh which had been rising since late June, touched ₹4,800-4,980 per 100kg. In the first week of August, prices touched a record of ₹5,350 per 100kg, August 18. A day later, ex-mill prices of sugar in Uttar Pradesh which had been rising since late June, touched ₹4,800-4,980 per 100kg.

international commodities firm asked, requesting anonymity. **How surplus turned to deficit** The sugar year's timeline tells the story. ISMA cut its gross sugar production estimate slightly in November, to 34.35 MT. Of this, about 3.4 MT was expected to be diverted for ethanol production, leaving net sugar production of 31 MT for food use. With opening stocks of about 5 MT, total sugar availability was projected at nearly 36 MT, against domestic consumption of about 28.5 MT, leaving a comfortable surplus that ISMA said could support exports of at least 2 MT. However, production estimates kept weakening. In February, ISMA cut its gross production estimate to 32.4 MT, a reduction of 1.95 MT over a month of the country's total sugar consumption. The industry body also reduced its estimate of net sugar production (the gross less ethanol) to 28.5 MT, against expected about 31 MT of sugar equivalent to be diverted towards ethanol. In April, the gross production estimate was cut again to 32 MT. The government now projects output for the ongoing season at 30.6 MT, with 2.9 MT diverted for ethanol and 800,000 tonnes exported, the leftover balance for the country stands at 26.9 MT, below the consumption estimate of 28.5 MT. However, buffer stocks in the country are at 28.5 MT, against expected about 31 MT of sugar equivalent to be diverted towards ethanol. In April, the gross production estimate was cut again to 32 MT. The government now projects output for the ongoing season at 30.6 MT, with 2.9 MT diverted for ethanol and 800,000 tonnes exported, the leftover balance for the country stands at 26.9 MT, below the consumption estimate of 28.5 MT. However, buffer stocks in the country are at 28.5 MT, against expected about 31 MT of sugar equivalent to be diverted towards ethanol.

A bitter harvest The sugar year's timeline tells the story. ISMA cut its gross sugar production estimate slightly in November, to 34.35 MT. Of this, about 3.4 MT was expected to be diverted for ethanol production, leaving net sugar production of 31 MT for food use. With opening stocks of about 5 MT, total sugar availability was projected at nearly 36 MT, against domestic consumption of about 28.5 MT, leaving a comfortable surplus that ISMA said could support exports of at least 2 MT. However, production estimates kept weakening. In February, ISMA cut its gross production estimate to 32.4 MT, a reduction of 1.95 MT over a month of the country's total sugar consumption. The industry body also reduced its estimate of net sugar production (the gross less ethanol) to 28.5 MT, against expected about 31 MT of sugar equivalent to be diverted towards ethanol. In April, the gross production estimate was cut again to 32 MT. The government now projects output for the ongoing season at 30.6 MT, with 2.9 MT diverted for ethanol and 800,000 tonnes exported, the leftover balance for the country stands at 26.9 MT, below the consumption estimate of 28.5 MT. However, buffer stocks in the country are at 28.5 MT, against expected about 31 MT of sugar equivalent to be diverted towards ethanol.

considerably more sugar than it ultimately did. Industry expected 4.5-MT of sugar equivalent to be diverted to ethanol. But oil marketing companies allocated only 2.9 billion litres of ethanol from sugar-based feedstocks for the 2025-26 ethanol supply year. ISMA had earlier estimated that around 3.2-3.4 MT of sugar would be diverted to ethanol production. In February 2027, wholesale sugar prices in key markets reached ₹4,080-4,180 per 100 kg. Market participants at the time tight stocks, strong bulk demand, speculative buying and lower production estimates. In a similar situation, ex-mill prices in 2009 touched ₹4,400 per 100 kg in key markets owing to a fall in acreage after bumper crop in 2007-08 disillusioned farmers and the monsoon failed in 2009. Closing stocks plunged to a critical low of 3.2 MT. India was forced to import over 4 MT of raw sugar, driving global prices to high prices. The government has maintained that ethanol did not lead to this price spike. In a statement released on August 21, it said the recent surge in sugar prices cannot be attributed to the diversion of sugar for ethanol, pointing instead to lower-than-expected domestic production, higher festive-season demand, and weather-related crop damage. The recent increase in sugar prices is attributable to a combination of factors, including lower-than-expected production, increased festive demand, weather-related crop damage, global supply conditions and market expectations. It cannot be attributed to ethanol diversion. The share of sugar diverted for ethanol has, in fact, declined from around 12% in 2022-23 to around 9% in 2025-26, while nearly three-fourths of etha-

no production now comes from sugarcane, particularly maize. **When were sugar prices last this high?** Sugar prices have never reached the highs witnessed this year. In this century, only two major episodes of tight domestic sugar supply were seen — first in 2009-10 and then in 2016-17. In February 2017, wholesale sugar prices in key markets reached ₹4,080-4,180 per 100 kg. Market participants at the time tight stocks, strong bulk demand, speculative buying and lower production estimates. In a similar situation, ex-mill prices in 2009 touched ₹4,400 per 100 kg in key markets owing to a fall in acreage after bumper crop in 2007-08 disillusioned farmers and the monsoon failed in 2009. Closing stocks plunged to a critical low of 3.2 MT. India was forced to import over 4 MT of raw sugar, driving global prices to high prices. The government has maintained that ethanol did not lead to this price spike. In a statement released on August 21, it said the recent surge in sugar prices cannot be attributed to the diversion of sugar for ethanol, pointing instead to lower-than-expected domestic production, higher festive-season demand, and weather-related crop damage. The recent increase in sugar prices is attributable to a combination of factors, including lower-than-expected production, increased festive demand, weather-related crop damage, global supply conditions and market expectations. It cannot be attributed to ethanol diversion. The share of sugar diverted for ethanol has, in fact, declined from around 12% in 2022-23 to around 9% in 2025-26, while nearly three-fourths of etha-

productivity concerns in crucial states of the country as a strengthening of the monsoon, the risk of hotter and drier conditions. Sugarcane needs intermittent rains to have a healthy yield. "Maharashtra and Karnataka account for almost 55% of the variability in national sugar production. Fluctuating rainfall and significant deficits in some parts of Maharashtra, very low reservoir levels in Karnataka and rainfall deficiency in eastern Uttar Pradesh and Bihar are all concerns. With (weather forecaster) Skymet also forecasting a rainfall deficit in September, we could see about 2 million tonnes less sucrose production in 2026-27 than this season," said GK Sood, chairman of KVAFSU. "It is already uncomfortable and less than the 14% seen during 2008-09 when stocks fell to low," he said. With opening stocks low, India imported as much as 5 MT of sugar in 2009-10, according to a Reuters report. Stock-to-use ratio refers to how much sugar is left in stock relative to annual domestic consumption. According to preliminary industry estimates, sugar output for the next 2026-27 may be even lower, at 28 million tonnes. In a response to HT's queries, the department of food and public distribution in a statement said, "The government will continue to closely monitor sugar availability, prices and market practices and take further measures, as necessary, to protect consumers while safeguarding the interests of sugarcane farmers," the statement added.

PICK OF THE DAY

MY BENGALURU

1.8mn deletions in SIR draft roll: CEO



Krishna Byre Gowda

IDENTIFY UNCLEAN PLOTS ACROSS CITY, ISSUE NOTICE TO OWNERS: MIN

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Greater Bengaluru Development minister Krishna Byre Gowda on Monday directed officials to identify vacant plots at all five City Corporations, serve notices to their owners, and promptly take up the cleaning work where owners fail to comply.

Chairing a virtual meeting to review the cleaning of vacant plots across Bengaluru, the minister noted that plot owners had been given time until August 22 to undertake the cleaning themselves. However, only around 20% of owners in some areas had complied with the deadline.

"Cleaning of vacant plots cannot be left to chance. The civic bodies must now identify the plots, serve notices and ensure they are cleaned. Wherever the civic body has to undertake the work, the cost should subsequently be recovered through the property tax," Gowda said.

Revenue officials have been directed to identify and prepare a list of vacant plots that require cleaning, he said, notices should then be served on the owners by marshals and Junior Health Inspectors, following which the respective civic bodies should undertake the cleaning wherever necessary.

The minister directed all five City Corporations to begin the cleaning drive from Thursday, with the exercise to be scaled up and implemented more intensively from the following Monday, his office said in a release.

The civic bodies have been asked to make all necessary arrangements, including KBIs, tipsters, tractors and manpower, to undertake the cleaning drive.

Abhishek Jha and Naheed Ataula

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NEW DELHI/BENGALURU: Around 10.8 million names, or 19.5% of the total electors, have been omitted in the draft electoral roll for Karnataka after the completion of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), marking the second highest deletion among the big states after 21.6% removal in Telangana at the draft stage.

On Monday, the Election Commission of India (ECI) published Karnataka's draft electoral roll, which has 44.6 million electors, 10.8 million (24.2%) less than the 55.4 million names on the rolls before the SIR exercise began on June 20 this year.

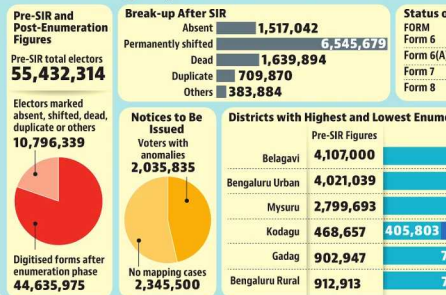
The SIR is a two-stage process. In the first stage, ECI directs states to identify and delete names of electors who are not mapped to the 2002 electoral rolls or those with discrepancies in the enumeration forms they have submitted.

Addressing a press conference in Bengaluru, Karnataka chief electoral officer (CEO) V Anubhukumar said the state had 55,432,314 electors in the pre-SIR electoral rolls as on June 16, 2026, and a total of 44,635,975 electors have submitted their enumeration forms and are included in the draft roll. Of these included, 22,159,240 are male, 22,473,864 female and 2,871 electors under the 'other' category, he added.

"Among the electors, 1,75,92,567 have completed self-mapping, which amounts to 39.42%. Another 2,49,32,908 have completed progeny mapping which amounts to 55.32%. The number of electors who have not provided any mapping information is 23,45,500," he said.

Analysing the age-wise data, the chief electoral officer said that the number of voters aged

Summing up the exercise so far



above 85 years is around 3,92,302.

"Keeping in mind the Election Commission's direction that only those electors who are not mapped to the 2002 electoral rolls at any polling station, around 1,873 polling stations have not been added. With this, the total number of polling stations in Karnataka is now 60,923, which was earlier 59,050," he said.

Following the completion of the enumeration phase (June 30 to August 17), the CEO said, 10,796,339 electors (or 19.48%) have been dropped from the list after both level officers (BLOs) marked them as Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate, and Others (ASDDO).

In the draft roll published on Monday, 23 million people are not mapped to the 2002 electoral roll and another 2 million have discrepancies, making around 4.4 million people included in the draft roll vulnerable to deletion in the final stage.

All these 4.4 million people stand removed in the final

roll, the total deletion in Karnataka from pre-SIR roll to final roll would stand at 15.2 million or 27.4%. To be sure, the final roll was smaller than the draft roll in only two states where SIR is now complete: Goa and West Bengal.

Anubhukumar said notices will be issued to 4,381,325 (9.82%) electors, whose forms had anomalies. The second stage—claims and objections phase—started on Monday and will conclude on September 23.

District-wise breakup of deletions in Karnataka show that they broadly follow the pattern seen in most states: deletions are generally higher in districts with higher urban population, although the relation is not always straightforward.

Bengaluru (with all its constituent urban population), it had an urban population share of 85% in the 2011 census, the highest in the state)

has seen its elector count shrink by 42.5%, the highest for any district. The second highest deletion is in Gulbarga, where the roll has shrunk

by 22%. Gulbarga was ranked only eighth by urban population share in the 2011 census. The third highest deletion is in Mysuru, which had the fourth highest urban population share in the 2011 census, where the roll has shrunk by 19.9%.

The lowest deletions are in Udupi, Haveri, and Uttara Kannada, where only 6%, 8.6%, and 8.7% electors, respectively, have been removed from the rolls. They were in the middle of the pack in urban population share in the 2011 census.

The districts with the highest deletions in absolute terms are the same as those with the highest percentage deletions, with a slight change in order. The highest deletions are in Bengaluru (all districts combined), where 4.5 million people are now off the rolls. Mysuru has seen 557,241 names removed from the rolls and Gulbarga has seen 521,957 names removed.

The lowest deletions in absolute terms are in Kodagu, Udupi, and Chamarajanager, where only 62,854, 63,331, and 88,275 names have been removed from the rolls.

The final electoral roll is scheduled to be published on October 27.

Around 4.68mn voters to receive notices in B'uru, says GBA chief

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BENGALURU: As many as 4.68 million voters in Bengaluru will be issued notices under various categories of discrepancies, data released by Bengaluru Urban district election officer and Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) chief commissioner M Maheshwar Rao on Monday showed.

Addressing a press conference, Rao said the lack in the draft rolls of names of those who were either shifted or were not present when the booth level officers visited their houses does not mean the names have been deleted.

In a separate news conference Karnataka chief electoral officer V Anubhukumar said Bengaluru North accounted for the highest number of notices that would be



GBA chief commissioner M Maheshwar Rao (right) addresses a press conference in Bengaluru on Monday.

sent. Of the total 12,80,085 enumeration forms filed in GBA (Bengaluru North), the anomalies accounted were 1,66,646 and for no mapping 4,46, 358. As a result notices would be issued to 6,13,004 voters.

In Bengaluru Central with 10,29,196 forms filled, the total

anomalies were 4,29,372 (41.72%) and in Bengaluru South 10,85,756 forms were filed, 4,17,631 (38.43%) notices would be issued.

Citizens can also verify their names in the electoral roll through the official website of the Chief Electoral Officer, Karnataka, and the GBA website.



Police detain council LoP Chavaladi Narayanaswamy during a protest march in Bengaluru on Monday.

Both Houses adjourned sine die 3 days early

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: The monsoon session of the Karnataka Legislative Assembly was curtailed by three days and adjourned 'sine die' on Monday, even as opposition heavyweights BJP and JD(S) intensified their protest to demand the removal of planning and statistics minister V Nagendra from the state cabinet.

The session was scheduled to conclude on August 27. Nagendra is facing charges in connection with the alleged embezzlement of crores of rupees at a state-run tribal welfare trust during his tenure as cabinet minister Siddaramaiah. He had subsequently resigned at the time.

After the session was adjourned, the BJP took out a march to Lok Bhavan, where Leader of Opposition in the assembly R Ashoka submitted a memorandum signed by all the BJP legislators. In the memorandum, the leaders urged governor Thawarchand Gehlot to ask minister DK Shivakumar regarding the present status of all CBI, Lokayukta and other proceedings concerning Nagendra. They urged Gehlot to seek an explanation as to what material circumstances have changed since Nagendra resigned from the earlier cabinet, warranting his re-induction despite the continuation of the same criminal proceedings.

"Please take all appropriate

BJP LEADERS LED BY LOP R ASHOKA URGED THE GOV TO SEEK ANSWERS OVER NAGENDRA'S RE-INCLUSION FROM THE CM DK SHIVAKUMAR

constitutional steps available to Your Excellency to ensure that Nagendra does not continue as a minister while criminal proceedings related criminal proceedings remain pending," the BJP leaders said.

Amid intense protest by the Opposition members holding placards and sloganeering in the well of the House and demanding Nagendra's resignation, Speaker S G Patil conducted proceedings, ensuring the transaction of legislative business with the passage of several Bills.

Several Bills, including the one allowing portion of park and garden and to be used for public infrastructure and utility projects, were passed by the Karnataka Legislative Assembly on Monday without discussion, amid the Opposition's protest.

The Speaker finally adjourned the House sine die, after ensuring the passage of supplementary estimates and related Bills tabled by chief minister D K Shivakumar.

The Legislative Council, which also witnessed similar protests, was also adjourned sine die.

UDUPI MAN KILLS PARENTS, GIVES HIMSELF UP DAY LATER, SAY POLICE

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UDUPI: A 31-year-old man was arrested on Monday for allegedly killing his parents with a hammer at their home in Udupi district, police said, adding that the accused stayed with the bodies through the night and confessed to police the next morning.

Udupi superintendent of police Hariram Shankar said the incident took place in Baiyadi village under Brahmarav taluk.

He said the accused called the emergency helpline at around 9 am on Monday and confessed that he had killed his parents at around 7 pm on Sunday evening, citing continuous mental harassment as the motive.

Police said the accused, who reportedly works as a food delivery executive, engaged in a petty quarrel with his parents before attacking both of them with a hammer, killing them on the spot.

He was taken into custody and a case was under Section 103 (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Further investigation is underway, said police.

The SP said that the accused alleged he had been mentally harassed and physically assaulted by his parents. He also said that his mental health would be assessed, adding that police were looking into claims that he was addicted to online gaming and the addiction may have contributed to the incident.

This claim needs to be verified through an examination of his mobile phone and other digital evidence," he said.

The mother's body was found in the bedroom, while the father's body was found in the living room. There were also clear signs of resistance found on both bodies, said police.

THE SP SAID THAT THE ACCUSED ALLEGED HE HAD BEEN MENTALLY HARASSED AND PHYSICALLY ASSAULTED BY HIS PARENTS



Legendary movie star Dr Rajkumar (inset) opened the theatre in 1970.

Demolition of iconic Urvashi theatre begins

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BENGALURU: The iconic Urvashi Theatre, which witnessed the release of thousands of movies in various languages in its 56 years of existence, will become a thing of the past.

Demolition of the single-screen theatre on Lalbagh Road here, which was inaugurated by the Kannada matinee idol Dr Rajkumar, began on Monday.

The theatre, with a total seating capacity of 1,100 was one of the biggest cinema halls in the city.

A regular filmgoer, Manohar Nagaraj recalled that it was common for audiences to come to Urvashi and celebrate whenever

films of their favourite stars were released.

"I saw many film actors coming here to promote their movies, and the audience going crazy for their favourite song, dialogue and actor appeared on the screen," he said. The process of demolishing this iconic theatre has started on Monday following a Supreme Court order that capped an 18-year legal battle.

Excavators on Monday began roaring at the site as workers removed seats and other equipment.

As people's emotions were attached to the theatre, officials said police personnel were deployed at the demolition site to avoid any law-and-order situation.

MAHA-BASED GANGSTER HELD IN CONG LEADER'S MURDER CASE

Press Trust of India
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UDUPI: A suspected Mumbai gangster wanted in connection with the murder of a local Congress leader in Udupi's Kapri taluk was arrested on Monday following a brief exchange of fire, officials said.

The accused, identified as Anuj Patil, was allegedly involved in the murder of David D'Souza, owner of Prince Enterprises, at the St Xavier Church Complex in Mudrangudy in Udupi district on August 7, they said. D'Souza was allegedly shot in the head with a pistol.

Police said a joint team from Kundapur and Kollur apprehended Patil within the limits of Hebri police station on Monday morning. While being taken into custody, he was attacked by a mob of local residents and relatives, and the total amount was found to be more than ₹8 lakh. Since ₹8.60 lakhs amount was discovered after her death, the circumstances under which it was accumulated and the manner in which

Kundapur PSI Nandana Naik then fired at Patil's leg in self-defence, police said. He was shifted to the district hospital at Aljarad in Udupi for treatment. Police said if cases have been registered against Patil in Maharashtra and other states, including under the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act.

Over ₹8L cash found hidden at beggar's home after last rites

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BENGALURU: Family members of an elderly woman who died in Mandya on Saturday after surviving on alms for several years found a sum of over ₹8 lakh in cash bundles of low-denomination notes hidden at her home after the last rites.

The woman, identified as Noor (88), died at her home in Guthulu locality, from age-related illnesses, said officials. After the funeral, some residents and relatives visited the house and were surprised to find sacks filled with coins and bundles of currency notes. The cash was counted in the presence of local residents and relatives, and the total amount was found to be more than ₹8 lakh.

Mandya superintendent of police Dr V Shobha Rani said the ₹8.60 lakhs amount was discovered after her death, the circumstances under which it was accumulated and the manner in which

LOCAL RESIDENTS SAID THE CASH WAS ARRANGED IN BUNDLES OF LOW DENOMINATION CURRENCY

it was handed over to her relatives after being looked into, the SP said. Locals said Noor had spent years begging on the streets and had apparently saved a significant portion of the money she received.

Following her death, local leaders reportedly intervened and, after discussions, the money was handed over to her relatives. Noor's brothers, who live in Bengaluru, were among those who found the money, locals said.

The incident has triggered questions among residents about the plight of elderly people living without family support. Several locals expressed concern that while Noor had struggled to meet her basic needs during her lifetime, the ₹8.60 million maintenance awarded to her by the court had not been sufficient to maintain minimum standards of living.

(with PTI inputs)

Husband cannot dictate wife's life choices: SC

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BENGALURU: Marriage is not a licence to control, command, dominate or conquer the individual, freedom and will of the other party, the state high court has recently held, noting that a husband cannot dictate where his wife goes, how she lives or compel her to perform household chores or care for his parents.

The court added that any attempt to restrict a woman's autonomy was "contrary to equality, human dignity and social justice."

Justice Chikkarumalatha said the observations in an August 3 order, where she dismissed a revision petition filed

by a man challenging a family court order directing him to pay ₹20,000 a month as maintenance to his wife and minor daughter.

The court took strong exception to the man's claim that his wife had left the matrimonial home and gone to her parents' home "without obtaining permission from him or his parents." Justice Sumalatha questioned why a married woman should need her husband's or in-laws' permission to visit her parents.

"This court does not understand why an Indian woman is required to take permission of all present at her matrimonial home to fulfil her basic desire of visiting her parents as and when she wishes and feels to go," the judge said.

THE HIGH COURT REJECTED THE ARGUMENT THAT A WIFE'S DEDICATION TO HER KIN COULD BE ASSESSED BY HER OBEDIENCE TO HER HUSBAND'S

The man's argument, the high court said, revealed his "mind-set" and his desire to "command and control the behaviour and wishes" of his wife.

"Anyone including husband cannot command and demand any female including his wife to do the household activities and to look after his parents," the

court said, adding that household activities "have to be shared by men and women equally".

If parents require care, the court said, the primary responsibility rests with their son or wife, "not the son-in-law or daughter-in-law." Care provided by a daughter-in-law or son-in-law, it said, must be voluntary. "A woman had the fundamental and absolute right to make decisions concerning her career, finances and other aspects of her life," the court said.

Justice Sumalatha also rejected the argument that a wife's dedication to her family could be assessed by how obediently she conformed to the expectations of her husband and his family.

"A wife's dedication to family can never be measured by obedience and submission," the court said. "Marriage is not a relationship between unequals," it added.

The man had claimed before the court that he earned his livelihood through physical labour and had to maintain his parents. He had sought a reduction in the ₹50,000 monthly maintenance awarded to his wife and ₹4,000 awarded for their minor daughter. The court, however, found no grounds to interfere with the Family Court's order.

It also observed that, given present-day prices and the cost of living, even ₹150 per person per day would not be sufficient to maintain minimum standards of living.

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REVANTH SLAMS CENTRE OVER DENIAL OF NOD FOR U.S. TOUR

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HYDERABAD: Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy on Monday attacked the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the NDA-led Union government over the denial of permission for his US visit, alleging that it was an insult to the 40 million people of Telangana and deliberate discrimination against the state.

Revanth Reddy, who returned to Hyderabad after completing his visit to London, told reporters at the state secretariat that he had no personal agenda for visiting the US. "I planned to visit the US to attract investments to Telangana under the State's Telangana Rising 2047 vision," he said, alleging that this was an attempt to prevent investments in Telangana.

"Denial of permission to the Telangana chief minister is not an insult to Revanth Reddy as an individual. It is an insult and rejection of four crore (40 million) people of Telangana," the chief minister said.

Two days on, no sign of 22 seafarers after ship sank off Odisha

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BHUBANESHWAR: Despite continuous searches by the Indian Navy and Coast Guard, there is no trace of the 22 crew members missing from cargo vessel MV Ocean Winner, two days after it sank in the deep waters of the Bay of Bengal, officials said.

The search operation, involving naval aircraft and Coast Guard vessels about 700 km east of Visakhapatnam, has so far found an oil slick near the vessel's last known position and two empty liferafts. Two Chinese crew members, Chen Jianhe and Pan Tonglai, were spotted floating on liferafts by a naval aircraft and rescued by crude oil tanker MT AISOPS.

The Panama-registered vessel, carrying more than 72,000 tonnes of iron ore from Paradip port in Odisha to China, sank about 230 nautical miles off the port.

"The vessel sank at a location in the Bay of Bengal where the sea is extremely deep," said Coast Guard spokesperson Commandant Amit Uniyal. "Both aerial search by



The China-bound ship with 24 crew members sank near Odisha coast on Saturday.

Naval plane as well as surface search operations by Coast Guard ships Varad, Anmol and Vijit are still going on. So far no debris have been found near the spot where the ship likely sank. But it is highly unlikely of any of the 22 crew members surviving."

The 225-metre Panamax bulk carrier had departed Paradip on August 20 with 72,000 tonnes of iron ore fines and 24 crew members—20 Chinese nationals, three Myanmar nationals and one Bangladeshi national. The two survivors, who are undergoing treatment, told rescuers that the vessel developed a heavy list on Friday evening and sank within about eight minutes, forcing the crew to abandon ship.

SC DECLINES TO LIST TEJPAL'S APPEAL UNTIL SURRENDER PLEA IS DECIDED

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday declined to list former Tehelka editor Tarun Tejpal's appeal against his conviction and 10-year jail term in the 2013 sexual assault case for hearing without first deciding whether he should be required to surrender. The court held that his plea for exemption from surrender must be considered before the appeal can be listed on merits.

Justice Alok Aradhya directed that Tejpal's application seeking exemption from surrender be taken up on Tuesday, after his counsel, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, sought listing of the application along with the appeal on August 31.

"...until and unless, suitable orders are passed on the application seeking exemption from surrender, the appeal cannot be listed before the court," said justice Aradhya, referring to an earlier judgment. The case relates to allegations that

Tejpal sexually assaulted a junior female colleague in Goa in November 2013. Tejpal has denied the allegations. mrc



{ ATTACKS ON GOVT WEBSITES }

NIA searches 5 locations in Op Sindoor cyber case

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NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Monday conducted searches at five locations across Maharashtra, Gujarat, Telangana, Bihar and Delhi in connection with a cyber-terrorism case involving attempted DDoS (distributed denial of service) attacks on 54 Indian government websites and targeting of critical information infrastructure (CII) during Operation Sindoor last year. The federal agency's case is based on a first information report (FIR) registered by the Gujarat Police in June last year. Operation Sindoor was

India's direct military response to the April 22, 2025, terror attack in Pahalgam, Kashmir, in which 26 people were killed.

The searches were conducted at Junnar in Pune, Nadiad in Gujarat's Kheda district, Ramagundam in Telangana's Karimnagar district, Gopalganj in Bihar and Delhi.

"During probe, suspects who provided support and assistance to the accused in the preparation and skill upgradation for carrying out the DDoS attacks were identified through thorough technical analysis," the NIA said. Searches were conducted at their premises after warrants were issued by the competent court.

CSAM mechanism plea: SC seeks Centre's reply

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday sought the Centre's response on a petition seeking establishment of a nationwide mechanism against the online circulation of Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM) and a dedicated probe agency to deal with such complaints.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said: "These issues are so serious that the judicial forum is not equipped to deal with them." However, the court agreed to know the stand of the Centre in this regard and issued notice to the Union government and CBI.

The order was passed on a petition filed by NGO Prajwala,

which has filed several pleas in the past on the issue.

The latest petition sought a host of orders which included a dedicated mechanism against circulation of CSAM and Non-Consensual Intimate Imagery, which is distinct from financial cyber fraud.

Besides, the petition sought establishment of a dedicated investigative agency. The petition also sought mandatory training and sensitisation of investigating agencies, prosecutors and judicial officers to deal with such victims.

To prevent circulation of such content, the plea demanded formulation of regulations to map active screening, detection and prevention mechanisms using AI-based tools.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



3 infants killed in fire at Amravati hospital

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NAGPUR: Three infants died while 36 others were rescued in the early hours of Monday after a ventilator explosion triggered a fire in the Special Newborn Care Unit (SNCU) of the District Women's Hospital in Amravati, Maharashtra, prompting the state government to order a high-level probe and enforce strict fire safety audits across healthcare facilities statewide.

Maharashtra chief Minister Devendra Fadnis termed the incident "extremely tragic and heart-wrenching", announcing ₹5 lakh in ex gratia for the family of each deceased infant. He also directed the Amravati district collector to ensure that all injured and rescued infants receive medical treatment at state expense.

According to officials, the fire broke out around 3.30am on the third floor of the newly constructed hospital building, which houses three SNCUs with a combined capacity of 39 infants.

As smoke filled the ward, nurses and medical staff manually disconnected life-support systems and rescued the infants. Of the 39 newborns across the three units, 36 were rescued.

Six critically ill babies from the affected section were shifted to three nearby private super-specialty hospitals, said officials.

Three infants in the out-born unit died from severe burn injuries and smoke inhalation, they added.



The fire broke in the SNCU on the third-floor of the newly constructed hospital building at around 3.30am.

According to Amravati Civil Surgeon Dr Vinod Pawar and police commissioner Rakesh Ola, the blaze erupted after a ventilator in the nine-bed out-born section suddenly exploded. Fire brigade officials, however, said an electrical short circuit might have caused the fire.

Swapnil Barge said he received the news of the death of his son hours after he informed his family about the birth. "Around 3.30am, I was standing at the hospital gate with a friend when I heard a woman shouting... Then there was an uproar, and the fire brigade came. I kept looking for my baby and wife, but couldn't find him."

Yogesh Savarkar, whose eight-day-old child was admitted on the first floor, recalled sleeping outside when panic erupted. "My child was on the first floor, and I personally went and brought him down," he told news agency PTI, adding that security guards and a nurse were the first to enter the

smoke-filled ward.

State health minister Prakash Abhikar visited the hospital and announced a seven-member expert committee headed by Public Health Commissioner Sanjay Katkar. The panel will submit its report within eight days. He added that Schiller Company (Nagpur), which supplied the ventilator, would be blacklisted, if equipment malfunction was established. A high-level meeting will also review fire safety compliance across state government hospitals.

Congress leader Yashomati Thakur, who visited the hospital, questioned the official claim of a ventilator explosion, noting that a similar fire had occurred at the facility previously.

Senior NCP (SP) leader and former minister Anil Deshmukh alleged that recommendations made by a committee following the 2021 Bhandara hospital fire, which had claimed the lives of 10 infants, had gone unimplemented.

[23 KILLED BY TERRORISTS]

1998 massacre of Kashmiri Pandits to be probed again

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SRINAGAR: The Jammu & Kashmir's State Investigation Agency (SIA) has reopened the Wandhama massacre case, 28 years after the terrorists gunned down 23 Kashmiri Hindus in central Kashmir's Ganderbal, officials familiar with the matter said.

The move is part of a wider effort to pursue long-pending cases of targeted killings during the peak of militancy in the valley. Several high-profile cases have been reopened since the abrogation of Article 370.

"The SIA has begun investigation into the Sarwanand Premi Koul, Tika Lal Taploo, and 1998 Wandhama massacre, in which 23 Kashmiri Pandits were killed, as part of a wider push to pursue long-pending cases of targeted killings during the peak of militancy in the valley," said a senior official privy to the details.

In January 1998, 23 Kashmiri Pandits from four families were killed by unidentified gunmen in Wandhama village. A 14-year-old was the lone survivor.

SIA has also reopened the 1990

murder of Article 370.

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SIA HAS ALSO FILED A CHARGE SHEET ON JUNE 29 IN THE 1990 RAPE AND MURDER OF KASHMIRI PANDIT NURSE SARLA BHAT

killings of Kashmiri Pandit writer and social worker Sarwanand Premi and his 24-year-old son, Virender Koul.

On August 12, the agency conducted raids at multiple locations

across Jammu & Kashmir in connection with the case.

In another major case, SIA has filed a charge sheet on June 29 in the 1990 rape and murder of Kashmiri Pandit nurse Sarla Bhat, naming JKLFC chief Mohammad Yasin Malik and Khurshid Ahmad Chalkoo as the alleged masterminds.

Lieutenant governor Manoj Sinha had announced on June 29, 2025, that cases involving people killed by Pakistan-backed terrorists during militancy would be reopened where families had not received justice. On July 1, he

directed officials to reopen such cases, register FIRs and ensure jobs for next of kin on priority.

SIA has also sought public help in the 1989 killing of judge Neel Kant Ganjoo and arrested two absconding terrorists accused in the 1990 killing of Mirwaiz Mohi Farooq.

Officials said several other old cases in which perpetrators remain at large are being investigated.

HT reached out to National Conference and the Kashmiri Pandit organisations but did not get a response till the time of print.

NO CONSTRUCTION WITHIN 100 METRES OF JOJARI RIVER: SC

JODHPUR: The Supreme Court on Monday barred all construction and development activity within 100 metres of the edge of Rajasthan's Jojari-Bandi-Luni river system until scientific demarcation of the High Flood Line and ecological buffer zones is completed.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta also barred hazardous industries or activities capable of polluting or damaging the river ecosystem within 500 metres on either side of the existing flood line or present flow path.

The court said the measures were necessary given the ecological degradation of the river. It also directed forthrightly compliance reports and involved NLU, Jodhpur in studying environmental law.

DINESH BOTHRA

Debris fall in Silkyara tunnel



Work to correct the geometry of the under-construction Silkyara-Barkot tunnel in Uttarakashi was disrupted by a sudden rush of debris on Friday, officials aware of the matter said, adding that no one was injured. In July, one worker was killed after a section of the concrete lining inside the 4.5-km tunnel collapsed.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

₹27,850-cr online scam, 163 FIRs: ED arrests two

Gerard de Souza

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PANAJI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has arrested two people for allegedly masterminding an elaborate "interconnected network of commodity, trading, travel and forex entities" that have together scammed more than 330 victims and have 163 FIRs registered against them across the country, involving fraudulent banking transactions exceeding ₹27,850 crore, the central agency said on Monday.

The accused, identified as Fahim Sayed and Naim Sayed, were arrested from Mumbai on Sunday by ED's Panaji zonal office in connection with a case, registered on June 03, by the Goa Police

Crime Branch where a woman from Goa alleged that she was coerced to transfer ₹2,60 crore during a "digital arrest" between May 21, 2025, and June 6, 2026, into accounts falsely described as "secret supervision accounts".

They were produced before the special PMLA Court in Goa and remanded to ED custody.

The victim's funds were routed within hours through dormant and newly opened accounts before being split across more than 400 beneficiary accounts. The trail led to a network of commodity, trading, travel and forex entities that together handled over ₹27,850 crore in banking transactions and deposited about ₹2,904 crore in cash, the ED said in a statement.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

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DELHI RAIN

deployed wherever required," an official said.

In Delhi, Janakpuri, Sadar Bazaar, Sangam Vihar, Zakhira, colonies around Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, Sainik Farms, Mahipalpur, Kamla Nagar, Vasant Kunj, Krishna Nagar and Kirti were hit the worst. Waterlogging was also reported near Connaught Place, ITO and outside the Supreme Court.

In Sadar Bazaar, traders said water entered shops in the Telwara area.

The area has been a mess this year and our businesses have suffered. Today, water entered our shops before the MCD could deploy pumps. Despite repeatedly informing the authorities, timely action is never taken," said Rakesh Yadav, president of the federation of Sadar Bazaar Traders association.

In Sangam Vihar, students waded through severely waterlogged roads.

"There is some ongoing work on the main road, because of which the road is flooded. There's a terrible smell even it's not raining. But after the rain, it becomes a complete gutter. We had no option but to wade through this stinking water to reach home," said Madhu, a student of Shivani Convent School in Sangam Vihar.

Water levels on an underpass leading towards the airport rose to around 1.5 feet, while vehicles were stranded near Mahipalpur flyover, creating bottle-necks that choked traffic and set off winding jams.

Traffic moved slowly on several arterial roads, including Ring Road, Outer Ring Road, MB Road, Kalindi Kunj Road, DND Flyway, NH-9, Vikas Marg, Mathura Road and Aurubhodi Marg. Routes around Sarai Kale Khan, Lalpat Nagar, South Extension, Sardarjung Hospital, Dhauka Kuan, Nehru Place, Okhla, Chirag Delhi and Munirka were particularly affected.

Gurgaon, meanwhile, came to a stop once again, as showers marmoured much of the city. WfH advisory.

The city received 75mm of rainfall till 3pm, prompting the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

Several key roads, including Rajiv Chowk, Subhash Chowk, NH-48, Narsingpur, Golf Course Extension Road, MG Road, IFFCO Chowk, Vatika Chowk and Sheela Mata Road, were inundated, with water reaching ankle-to-knee depth at several stretches.

At Subhash Chowk near Rail Vihar in Sector 47, several

school buses were stranded. Taruna Bhatia, a Sector 70 resident, said her child had been stuck on the road since 1pm. "It was extremely worrying," she said.

Monday's showers were the latest illustration of the pitfalls of Gurugram's civic infrastructure, which has buckled at the lightest spoils of rain.

The mess in Noida and Ghaziabad was comparable, where the showers triggered waterlogging and traffic snarls.

According to IMD, the Noida KVK Chibhola station recorded 70mm of rainfall from 8.30am on Sunday to 8.30am on Monday and another 0.5mm of rain till 5.30pm.

IMD forecast a partly cloudy sky with one or two spells of rain or thundershowers for Tuesday for the two districts, though it stopped short of issuing a colour-coded alert.

Delhi, meanwhile, has so far received 280.4mm rain this August, 50mm more than the long-term average for the month (IMD) long-period average for the month, with a week still to go.

More rain is likely in store for the region on Tuesday, said IMD officials, with very light to light showers at many places and moderate rain at isolated places expected during the day.

(With inputs from Sampurna Panigrahi and Mihika Shah)

CIP PLANS NEW MARCH

been invited to participate in the event.

But a senior Delhi Police officer said that the department had not received any request for a march or protest, adding that prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita are already in force in the New Delhi district area where India Gate is located, and that protests and marches are only allowed near Jantar Mantar with prior permission.

The last notable protest or march along Jantar Mantar in India Gate was in 2012, in the aftermath of the December gang-rape and murder.

The decision came after the CIP's national working committee reviewed the status of commitments made by the Union government and National Democratic Alliance-ruled states, following the withdrawal of the protests on July 25, the party said.

"Members of the committee expressed serious doubts over whether the government intends to honour its word at all. For a month now, instead of implementing what was solemnly promised, the government played delay games, hidden behind technicalities, and avoided giving clear

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

commitments even before the Supreme Court of India," the party said in a statement.

The withdrawal of all cases and the first information reports (FIRs) was part of the three conditions—the others being the resignation of former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan and Rs 1 crore compensation to the families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide—involvement in calling off the Jantar Mantar stir on July 25.

To be sure, states such as Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Assam, West Bengal and Maharashtra have announced that they will not take any legal action against people participating in protests. But in no state have FIRs been withdrawn. In Delhi itself, at least 13 FIRs were registered under various sections of the BNS, including attempt to murder and criminal conspiracy and prevention of defacement of public property etc. All cases were against unknown people.

During the meeting on June 25, Union minister JP Nadda said the CIP representatives came to the meeting with a written draft on cases filed during the July 20 agitation. "After the discussion, the first point was that no action should be taken and no FIRs should be filed. If any FIRs have already been registered, whether by the Delhi Police or in BJP-ruled states, it will be withdrawn," Nadda had said.

Last week, the Supreme Court had also returned to the issue of FIRs, while announcing the setting up of a high-powered committee. Solicitor general Tushar Mehta had said that the Centre and Delhi Police were not opposing the quashing of FIRs against student protesters, but maintained that persons with serious criminal antecedents who had allegedly infiltrated the protests could not be treated on the same footing.

The bench, however, had said that the authorities could not leave such persons as a generic category of "undesired elements" and would have to identify them. "Your agency must have identified those who were students and the others who were undesired elements. Unless we have the list, how are we going to quash it?" the bench had asked.

The court had also stressed that the students participating in a peaceful and lawful protest have constitutional protection under Article 19, while distinguishing them from persons with serious criminal antecedents who may have entered the gathering and indulged in violence.

The CIP alleged that the top court repeatedly sought a list of FIRs registered across the country so that it could consider dealing with them together. "Yet, the Union government refused to give a clear commitment to do so," the party said, adding that the written

assurance it said was promised by the government also remained pending.

CIP chief spokesperson Saurav Das said the organisation had decided to resume peaceful mobilisation after the government failed to fulfil the assurances that led to the withdrawal of the earlier agitation. "The Cockerock Janta Party calls for a peaceful protest march at India Gate, New Delhi on September 5," Das said on X.

The CIP statement said the latest mobilisation was a response to what it described as the government's failure to act on the assurances. "This cannot continue. Our patience cannot be mistaken for weakness. Our good faith cannot become an opportunity for the Government to betray us," the statement said.

The party said the families of NEET aspirants who died would walk at the front of the march, with victims of police brutality alongside them. It also appealed to students and young people to gather at India Gate on September 5 and participate in the march peacefully.

The CIP first garnered millions of followers on social media before launching an indefinite sit-in protest on June 20 demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan over repeated question paper leaks—including one earlier this year. After days of tepid crowds, the movement was galvanised by the hunger strike and forcible removal of activist Sonam Wangchuk last week.

Crowds swelled through the weekend and by July 20, columns of people—many of them students, first-time agitators and young professionals—had defied a steady drizzle and police barricading to join what became the largest street protests in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's third term. Over 20 protesters and 230 security personnel were injured.

After the July 20 protests, crowds swelled and spilled beyond the confines of Jantar Mantar as thousands of young people poured into central Delhi, despite the longest spells of internet shutdown and metro station closure in Delhi, scores of barricades that sparked traffic snarls across the Capital, and controversial police detention from roads over protesters carrying posters or pepper spray.

As the storm of Gen Z protesters grew, the government's efforts to break the impasse kicked into overdrive. Nadda and Singh convinced Wangchuk to break his fast. Modi made a rare personal appeal to young people on Instagram and promised a stringent new bill—which was eventually passed in the monsoon session—to tackle paper leaks, and the National Testing Agency fired top officials.

IRAN CONFLICT

Qalibaf said the U.S. is not in an economic position to further restrict Tehran's relations with other countries.

In Iran's trading partners, both in the media and through messages sent to us, have made it clear that they don't take these statements into account anywhere," Qalibaf, who has been Iran's lead negotiator over the past six months, posted on X.

Hours before Bessent's announcement, Iran's currency hit a record low.

The rial dropped to 2,02 million to the U.S. dollar as trading opened on currency markets. Iran's official Central Bank rate stood at around 15 million rial to the dollar, but the market rate was what most Iranians pay.

The currency had already been under pressure before the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran on Feb. 28, as Iran faced double-digit inflation and negative growth. The rial has repeatedly hit new lows as nearly six months of war have taken an even greater toll. Iranians find daily staples increasingly unaffordable. Since the war began, rice is up some 60% and beef prices are more than 150% higher. The International Monetary Fund forecasts that gross domestic product will contract more than 5%.

Still, economic pressure has not yet translated into political pressure. Iran retains a key strategic advantage: Its attacks and threats on ships in the Strait of Hormuz have brought traffic in the vital waterway to a near halt, damaging the world economy and heaping pressure on U.S. President Donald Trump ahead of congressional elections.

The war, as a result, has devolved into a fight over who controls the strait, through which a fifth of the world's traded oil transited before the conflict. Iran is now refusing to fully reopen it unless it can charge ships.

Iran and Oman, which is on the opposite side of the strait, are reportedly in the final stages of agreeing on a plan for joint management of the waterway. Oman's foreign minister is set to visit Iran on Tuesday.

Pakistan, which played a key role in brokering a 60-day ceasefire in June, sent a high-level delegation to Iran on Monday to encourage the U.S. and Iran to return to negotiations, two senior officials said. The officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to the media on the record.

The military confirmed only Field Marshal Asim Munir's visit, saying it was aimed at de-escalating tensions in the region.

CID probes multi-state ₹10k-cr 'chit-fund' fraud

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BHOPAL/ABALPUR: The Madhya Pradesh Criminal Investigation Department (CID) has unearthed a suspected chit-fund fraud involving more than ₹10,000 crore and nearly 35 million investors across 17 states, officials aware of the matter said on Monday. Owners and officials of 10 companies have been booked in the case, they added.

According to CID officials, the accused floated fake companies under different names in several states and lured people with promises of doubling their investments within a short period. "They collected deposits through local agents and managers, while funds were ultimately transferred to company owners," said a CID note.

In Madhya Pradesh alone, more than 210,000 people invested ₹492 crore in the companies, the officials said.

CID inspector general Rajvardhan Maheshwari said, "We received 11 case files related to chit-fund fraud in Ashoknagar, Thanggarh, Damoh, and Vidisha districts. The investigation revealed that 1,600 investors were cheated of more than ₹42 crore."

He added that the accused registered their societies with the Central Cooperative Society under the ministry of agriculture and farmers welfare instead of at the state level, enabling them to operate across states. CID has named 16 accused in the case. "We are investigating how the entire nexus is being operated across India," Maheshwari said.

"The companies operated in 17 states, including Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, Uttarakhand, Assam, Bihar, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Odisha, West Bengal, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Karnataka, and Punjab. FIRs have been registered in these states as well," he added.

WEARING HIJAB IS NOT AN ESSENTIAL PART OF ISLAM: HC

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court has dismissed a petition seeking direction to school authorities to allow a girl student to wear a headscarf (hijab) in addition to the uniform, observing that it is not an essential part of Islam.

"Wherever this issue has arisen, the high courts have been unanimous in opinion that wearing a headscarf is not essential part of the Islamic faith for a woman to don, in the absence of which, faith would be jeopardized," the bench of justices JJ Munir and Indrajit Shukla said.

The petition filed by a student of a private school in Prayagraj, asking for directions to school authorities to permit her to wear a hijab.

"We have perused the photographs from various classes relating to the petitioner. Except for her, no other girl student is donning the headscarf, even those belonging to the same religious community, as the petitioner," the bench said.

In its August 21 order, the court further observed, "There is no pleading or authoritative religious text or material placed on record, sufficient by itself to establish that the practice asserted by the petitioner is obligatory upon her, and the non-observance thereof would alter the fundamental character of her faith." HC

WAZE INFLUENCED POSTMORTEM REPORTS, ALLEGES DISHA'S FATHER

MUMBAI: Deceased celebrity manager Disha Salian's father Satish Salian on Monday made a fresh claim against dismissed police officer Sachin Waze, alleging that the former cop had played a key role in derailing the investigation into his daughter's death during the initial stages.

In an affidavit to Bombay high court, Satish's advocate Nilesh Olphar claimed that Waze had manipulated Disha's postmortem reports to indicate that she had died by suicide, adding that she was actually gang-raped and murdered at the behest of Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aditya Thackeray, actors Dino Morea and Suraj Pancholi.

Disha, whose clients included actor Kushen Singh Rajput, died after falling from the 14th floor of a residential building in Malad on June 8, 2020. The police registered an accidental death report, but Rajput's death six days later fuelled intense speculation about the circumstances. The police, however, ruled out any foul play. In his petition, Satish claimed that Disha was subjected to brutal sexual assault and murder as she had become aware of the sexual assault of a minor girl at a party, as well as a drug syndicate allegedly run by Aditya Thackeray.

15-year-old girl raped at Guwahati homestay, 5 held

SILCHAR: Five people were arrested in Guwahati for allegedly abducting and raping a 15-year-old girl in a homestay, police said on Monday. According to police, the girl went missing on August 22 and her family members lodged a missing report at Dadara Police Station on August 23. Two of the five accused are the homestay staff members.

Being offered TVK Kerala president's post, says actor THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Actor and former Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Devan said on Monday that the Tamilaga Vettri

Kazhagan (TVK) has offered him the post of the party's Kerala unit president and that he would hold final round of discussions with party chief and Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay in this regard on September 10.

"They (TVK leadership) have verbally offered me the post of the state president of the party in Kerala... But Vijay will take the final decision," he told reporters.

Abhishek's bank account working, HC disposes plea KOLKATA: The Calcutta high court on Monday disposed of a petition by TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee, noting that his bank account, debit and credit cards, which were frozen, were reactivated following submission of KYC documents by him to a private bank.

Banerjee's lawyer Ayan Bhattacharjee had claimed that the TMC MP's bank account had been frozen and his debit and credit cards blocked on August 10, when the Supreme Court permitted him to travel abroad for medical reasons.

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FIRST. LAST. WORD.

{ OUR TAKE }

Open up space, with caution

India can accelerate privatisation of the space economy by allowing easier talent mobility

Space has, even before *Star Trek* made the phrase popular, always been the final frontier. Exploring the unknown has come to mark not just a country's scientific ambitions, but also become a measure of its industrial capabilities, something that marks its technological, economic, and geopolitical dominance. The US and Russia engaged in an intense competition over space in the 1960s, and it can be argued that the former's victory in it—with the moon landing—heralded its arrival as a technology leader, something that holds true even today.

India, an impressive contender in space-tech, thanks to ISRO's remarkable strides, now faces the challenge of building on its competence in delivering high-value space-tech on much smaller budgets than the US and China, its two main rivals (Russia has fallen back). PM Narendra Modi's exhortation to private space-sector players during an interaction on Friday, to position India as a global space-tech hub recognises this.

India began pivoting towards greater private sector participation some years ago, with ISRO passing on technology. The successful launch of India's first private orbital carrier, Skyroot's Vikram-I, shows maintaining momentum, let alone increasing it, requires greater private sector participation. Two considerations point at this. One is the State-run programme's *raison d'être* at this stage of India's space sector evolution. Space exploration, where commercial value may not be immediately apparent, needs the State's reserves, and splitting these reserves with the space-applications side may not be the optimal use of public funds. The US understood this decades ago. And greater private sector participation can unlock more value, faster, which can also reward the public sector. Private firms developing reusable rockets and landers can help ISRO, too. They can also raise private money more efficiently.

India can accelerate the process by lifting restrictions on talent mobility. Global space-tech talent should see value and ease in setting up shop in India, even as domestically nurtured talent is not shackled. While constraints on capital have been loosened to a great degree in some areas, further easing can be considered after careful balancing against strategic concerns. Most importantly, competition needs to thrive. Real and effective monopolies and duopolies don't help India's long-term vision in any sector. The formula is old, but it merits repetition—especially since it can ensure a commanding position for India in the space economy.

Public health work must go beyond advisories

As swine flu cases rise in the national capital, the administration has advised people to wear masks in crowded places, wash hands frequently, avoid contact with anyone who appears to be infected, and consult a doctor if they develop flu-like symptoms. Such advice may be useful, but the larger question remains unanswered. In cities defined by density—where people live, study, work, commute, shop, and socialise in closely packed spaces—can close contact among residents realistically be limited to control the spread of infections? One could argue that physical distancing was an important part of the Covid-19 containment strategy, but that was a once-in-a-lifetime pandemic needing extraordinary measures, including lockdowns, travel restrictions, alongside masking, testing and other interventions. Influenza A (H1N1), by contrast, is a seasonal viral circulation that public-health systems should routinely manage. Annual flu shots can prevent outbreaks (and boost herd immunity), but they are expensive, with the cheapest costing around ₹1,000. The government could consider vaccinating at least frontline health care and sanitation workers, though.

The challenge is also one of India's urban governance. Overheated spaces, flooded and potholed streets, overflowing drains turning into vector-breeding sites, and toxic winter smog are treated as seasonal woes. Density isn't something governments can control, but ensuring that growing populations are adequately served certainly is. Urban built environments can be dense, and still be managed for public well-being.

The Covid-19 pandemic exposed entrenched health inequities in India. To address these, our cities need guaranteed access to primary care and testing in every neighbourhood. Markets, public transport systems and other crowded spaces need practical infection-control protocols, activated when outbreaks occur. Severely compromised public hygiene needs stronger municipal systems, better housekeeping, and greater public participation. Better advisories that place the onus on the population can't be the only government action

Can AI clean India's air? Only with the basics right

AI-driven air quality management systems can enable faster, better decision-making, provided they are secure, safe, and genuinely tailored to end-users' requirements

In a little over two months, winter will descend on the Indo-Gangetic Plain, and with it, the familiar smog. For over three crore people in Delhi-NCR, this means tracking the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) directed by the Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas (CAQM), and planning their activities. The CAQM will rely on the Air Quality Early Warning System's (AQEWS) forecasts to decide which stage of GRAP to impose.

The AQEWS is remarkably accurate. According to a study by the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), it can predict days with air quality index (AQI) of 300 and above with over 80% accuracy. A series of studies—the Great Smog of 2016, the pollution episodes of 2017, the deadly dust storms of 2018—gave birth to this system. Today, seven other cities beyond Delhi have their own AQEWS: Pune, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Ahmedabad, Kolkata, Mumbai, and Jaipur.

Crises gave us a generation of digital air quality management tools. The current spurt of artificial intelligence (AI) offers newer, better ones. But we must tread with caution. How these tools are used, and how they are designed, will determine whether they become a long-term paradigm shift or end up in the graveyard of obsolete technology.

First, adopt AI-driven air quality decision support systems (AQDSS) and incorporate end-user feedback from day one. Air quality data comes from monitoring stations, models and forecasts, low-cost sensors, emission inventories and custom surveys. Gathering it on a single platform, analysing it, and drawing actionable insights is challenging. Traditional decision support systems such as the AQEWS simplify these tasks, but still require skilled personnel to navigate them and convert data into action.

Such AI-enabled systems bring air quality managers closer to action by eliminating complex multi-step processes. Through simple natural language queries—like one would type on a mobile phone—managers can get insights while the AI runs complicated analytical tasks in the background, presenting only what matters. But involving the end user in system design must be negotiable. A CEEW study found that even well-designed decision support systems could fail if they do not account for how end-users engage with them.

Regular feedback from decision-makers ensures systems are designed around their actual requirements. IIT Gandhinagar and CEEW recently developed a forthcoming AI application called *Vayam*. That integrates data from over 300 low-cost air

quality sensors installed at construction sites in Thane, Maharashtra, and helps the municipal corporation identify sites that exceed pollution thresholds or fail to relay data. The system incorporated feedback from officials in the mock-up stage itself. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's collaboration with IIT Kanpur on an AI-enabled decision-support system that draws real-time insights from 75 sensors across Mumbai is another good model of end-user collaboration.

Second, build capacity to use AI-driven systems well and to intervene when they go wrong. Replacing traditional DSS with AI does not eliminate the need for capacity-building. The quantity of output depends on the clarity and depth of the user's questions. Personnel still need a deep understanding of air quality and the training on feeding effective prompts. These systems are not foolproof either. If a system meant to monitor 500 construction sites daily has an error rate of even 1%, it would flag 50 sites as problematic when they are not. Having humans in the loop who can judge AI output and make decisions is essential. Agencies adopting AI-powered systems must ensure adequately trained personnel are in place before widespread deployment.

Third, ensure these systems are secure and invest in local AI models and applications. Air quality management involves sensitive data that could relate to government finances, enforcement patterns, and compliance histories. Such data should be



Air quality is a national problem. AI models and applications to better manage it should be considered a priority.

analysed locally using offline AI models and not transmitted to external data centres. Security aside, bespoke offline models will also liberate government organisations from the usage constraints that come with online models. The best AI models available today have been developed abroad and carry risks of restrictions, such as models and applications to better manage. Anthropic's advanced models. This calls for developing cutting-edge indigenous models. That also carries a risk of failure, and government bodies should have an appetite for it by supporting research institutes and start-ups developing better models and applications.

The Centre's India AI Mission is an encouraging step in the right direction. With an outlay of over ₹1 billion and 38,000 OupUs, it aims to de-risk the development of innovative applications across agriculture, health care, weather forecasting and governance—all domains closely linked to air quality. With a comprehensive plan that includes indigenous AI models, housing innovative datasets, upskilling programmes, and access to computa-

Arunabha Ghosh is CEO, the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), member, Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), and chair, AI and Climate Expert Group for the India AI Impact Summit.

Mohammad Rafiuddin is programme lead at CEEW.

The views expressed are personal



WILL RAIDS MAKE OUR FOOD SAFER?

{ OP SINGH } FORMER IPS OFFICER

{ PUSHPESH PANT } ACADEMIC

Strict enforcement cannot bridge institutional gaps

Tukaram Mundhe is the latest knight in shining armour to have emerged—the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) chief who took over the hearts of Mumbai restaurants, many of which may have relegated the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) and its regional representatives to the taxidermist's table as a toothless, long-dead tiger.

MNCs and Indian food joints alike are scurrying for cover; many, generally considered reputable, are shell-shocked to find licences suspended for months after inspections. Mundhe has even cracked down on sellers of food commodities sold loose that are especially prone to adulteration.

Why, then, is this saviour not being greeted with grateful hosannas but causing chills to run down many spines across the country? It doesn't require rocket science to unravel the mystery. Enforcement, over the past few years, has become synonymous with bureaucratic overreach, almost bulldozing in nature. And there has been an incomprehensible reluctance from the judiciary to keep this in check. In such a scenario, the material and reputational damage incurred by the targeted party has often been irreparable.

Two sayings sum things up here, the one about good intentions paving the path to hell and TS Eliot's poetic observation about the shadow falling between conception and creation (execution, in the bureaucratic context). Both the FSSAI and, now, the Maharashtra FDA seem unaware of adages and poetic warnings.

There was a time when the FSSAI had aroused hopes that it will partner with street food vendors and small eateries to help them adopt best practices in handling and producing food hygienically, and leverage standards to prosper. The authority spent much energy making consumers aware of the significance of labels and packaging, statutory warnings, and expiry dates.

But it wasn't long before the fine print became so small that no one would willingly squint to read it. Word wizardry did the rest. Sugar-free, zero trans fats, nature identical, etc., could confuse even the experts when numbers from some technical list followed in parentheses.

The Bombay High Court has, according to reports, rapped Mundhe lightly on the knuckles for suspending the licences of parties that had registered 98% compliance. But will this admonishment be enough to rein in other Don Quixotes (individuals and institutions alike)?

Some harsh realities certainly can't be wished away. Can compliances be ensured with multiple enforcement agencies exercising their jurisdiction in the same space—to illustrate, municipal and other licensing authorities and beat police constables who look the other way with a wink after some grease money has been received? These now operate a complex web of relationships premised on a crude understanding of the "live and let live" principle that can't be undone overnight.

India is a country where the majority sur-

Crusaders are built and scapegoats are found, swiftly punished even as institutional problems linger



views on natural immunity acquired to withstand the microbes in tap water, often due to the confluence of sewage-pipe contents and waste water deemed fit for human consumption.

It is the same for adulterated food grains and oils. Hoarding and black marketing have proved impossible to exterminate. Pathogens have become drug-resistant. It is definitely not the optimal condition, but can we really beat the virus?

The punishment prescribed by law is mandatory, but conviction needs much rigour to earn. So, the process is often made the punishment. Food safety and standards laws, like many other pieces of legislation, are meant to deliver public good but can also be weaponised by governments against political opponents. After decades-long deep slumber, food safety laws are being awakened to a scheduled electoral battle wake up and discover that offenders have violated fire or food safety norms. Those who suffer are often the small fry, not the sharks. At such times, parliament, even section 32, patronage could undermine the governance intent of enforcement.

Returning to the sale and purchase of loose food commodities—and keeping aside the question of adulteration for a moment—this is certainly not a choice. The poor have almost no other option to turn to. But the government and authorities need to act and, more importantly for them, be seen to have acted to safeguard public interests.

So, crusaders are built and scapegoats are found, swiftly punished even as institutional problems linger. And in present times, the problem has become even more challenging—no one knows what happens when tech-savvy producers collaborate with aggregator platforms and sell us sub-par food.

Pushpesh Pant is an academic, writer and food-critic. The views expressed are personal

Activist officers are fine, but steady action brings change

I was in Mumbai recently to watch a friend take his company public. He began in 2008 and built something India used to sport: the proprietary system of a railway engine. That evening, we dined at one of the city's famous hotels. The food was stale. The reason may have been anything—a slow evening, a careless hand, I make no accusation. But my own reaction surprised me: I silently thanked Tukaram Mundhe for tearing down kitchen doors across Maharashtra.

For decades, this country absorbed filth in food as its own standard until the law against it read like a foreign document. It has taken an officer willing to be widely disliked to make us look. Thirty-three years among officers taught me how rare and how costly that willingness is.

And yet, the two careers sat side by side in my mind all week. My friend, the founder, started in 2008 and stayed in one place. The officer started in 2005 and has passed through 25 offices, gaining national attention in his 21st year, for a hygiene drive. Both men are builders by temperament: impatient, exacting, and contemptuous of the excuse. Only one of them has built something that will live his presence in the room.

Indian officers are moved constantly and cheaply: An analysis of some 2,800 IAS careers found the average tenure to pass was 16 months, with a 53% chance of transfer in any given year—worse in a new chief minister's first months, worse again when the ruling dispensation changes. A suspension needs charge and a prosecution needs sanction; a transfer needs one line and a signature. Some of any crusader's postings are receipts for refusals he should be proud of.

Twenty-five postings in 21 years is about ten months per chair—40% shorter than the punishing national average. Mundhe was moved faster than the ordinary Indian officer. A gap that is rarely available information. I do not claim to read his heart. I am pointing at a pattern, and at the possibility, that holding a post is itself a professional skill, one that can be practised or neglected like any other. It can certainly be practised; E. Sreedharan was given the Konkan Railway in 1990 and finished it in seven years over terrain that had defeated planners for a century. Then, came the Delhi Metro, where he stayed until his retirement in 2011—the better part of two decades in one chair, sections delivered on time and within budget.

He was no more upright than the honest officers I served with, and he raised nobody. What he had was the political skill to hold ground: He negotiated his autonomy and spent the tenure he had won on building concrete structures rather than on television.

Under 4,721 projects across 63 government organisations in Nigeria, Inran Rasul and Daniel Rogger found that greater autonomy for officials raised project completion rates by about 18%, while heavier monitoring and incentive regimes lowered them by

Holding a post is itself a professional skill, and it can be practised or neglected like any other



around 14%. Autonomy, though, is negotiated, defended, and renewed—work a crusade would treat as compromise. Lawrence Sherman's review of 18 police crackdowns found that 15 produced initial deterrence that then decayed, in many cases while the crackdown continued at full strength. Fear expires on its own schedule, and a news cycle demands escalation, until a food safety drive is mounted by what holds attention rather than by what actually makes food safe.

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) already has a Hygiene Rating Scheme that scores restaurants and sweet shops—and it is voluntary. The portal lets a citizen look up only single eateries and publishes no total. A rating system that doesn't establish a total count is a filing cabinet, not a public instrument.

In a LocalCircles survey published on August 12, drawing over 9,000 responses across 244 districts, 74% wanted the display of hygiene ratings made mandatory. New York, since 2010, has had a grade posted at every restaurant window; salmonella has since fallen by 5.3% a year against the rest of the state. Make such rating compulsory in Maharashtra, and one season's raiders become a permanent instrument.

So, could Mundhe have held on somewhere in these 25 years to date? Part of the answer lies in a State that spends its officers like small change. Part lies with the officers themselves, and in a profession that has begun to make motion for merit.

My friend spent 18 years in one place, through a financial crisis and years of certification, because that is what building anything big requires. The same is true in government. It is a tragedy that officers are transferred frequently. The bigger tragedy is that more transfers are directed as merit.

OP Singh retired as director general of police, Haryana. The views expressed are personal



Govt plans to privatise 11 airports in five bundles

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: The government is planning to privatise 11 airports in the country by grouping them into five bundles with the aim of subsidising smaller airports with the earnings of larger ones to make them sustainable in the long term.

The five bundled airports are: Amritsar and Kangra-Gaggal; Varanasi, Gaya and Kushinagar; Bhuvaneshwar and Hubballi; Raipur and Aurangabad; and Tiruchirappalli and Tirupati, according to the minutes of an August 4 meeting of the Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPAPAC), Central sector Public-Private Partnership (PPP) projects above ₹250 crore have to get an appraisal from the PPAPAC, which is chaired by the secretary, department of economic affairs.



In 2018-19, the government privatised six airports.

subsidisation from the revenues of larger airports," the minutes said.

In 2018-19, the government privatised six airports operated by the Airports Authority of India under the Public Private Partnership model. The Adani Group emerged as the winning bidder for all six airports—Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Mangalore, Jaipur, Thiruvananthapuram, and Guwahati.

In response to observations by the chair, the aviation ministry said the number of airport bundles that may be awarded to a single bidder would be capped to "mitigate the risks arising from market concentration and potential over-leveraging, including their possible cascading impact across pro-

jects," the minutes showed. The details of the cap are being worked out and would be submitted as part of the proposal for a final PPAPAC clearance, the document said.

In response to another observation by the department of expenditure, the aviation ministry said that it was proposed to permit participation by bidders with relevant cross-sectoral infrastructure experience, not just in the aviation sector.

For the present round, AAI adopted a phased and data-driven approach to identify airports suitable for PPP and bundling, as per the minutes of the meeting.

"Initially, 12 major airports were assessed based on passenger traffic, land availability and commercial potential, financial performance, and airport-specific strengths and constraints, of which six were recommended for leasing. Subsequently, 136 smaller airports were evaluated for possible bundling with the major airports, based on parameters including traffic potential, capital expenditure requirements, geographical proximity, city-side development potential and financial viability," the document stated.

Under the proposed arrangement, it stated, the private concessionaire will be responsible for the operation, management, and development of the airports, including passenger terminals and city-side infrastructure. The concession period will be 50 years.

AAI, however, will continue to provide air traffic control and communication, navigation, and surveillance services. It also stated that AAI's wholly owned subsidiary, AAI Cargo Logistics and Allied Services Company Ltd (AAICLAS), will continue to undertake cargo operations.

As per the document, the proposal also provides for a one-year joint management period involving existing AAI employees, after which the concessionaire will be required to retain 60% of AAI employees for up to three years.

Before seeking the PPAPAC's final recommendation, MoCA will conduct a market-sounding exercise with infrastructure players to assess their response to the proposed bundling arrangement, according to the document.

AAI will also review feedback from private operators, which may result in modifications to the proposal, it said.

The aviation ministry did not respond to the development.

Wheat export ban lifted amid global supply flux

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NEW DELHI: India on Monday removed restrictions on wheat exports, allowing traders to ship the grain and flour freely after months of quota-based exports, as comfortable government stocks eased food-security concerns. However, traders said the policy change may not immediately translate into large shipments because Indian wheat remains too expensive for most overseas markets.

The Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT), in a notification dated August 24, revised the export policy for durum wheat and other wheat from "Prohibited" to "Free" with immediate effect. The move comes alongside a separate notification freeing exports of wheat flour and related products, including atta, maida and semolina.

The government had initially allowed wheat exports only in limited quantities. It first opened a 2.5 million tonne quota in February and later approved another 2.5 million tonnes, taking the total quantity permitted for export to 5 million tonnes.

The restrictions are now being removed altogether,



The government had initially allowed wheat exports only in limited quantities.

against the backdrop of a much stronger domestic supply position. Food Corporation of India wheat stocks stood at 50.5 million tonnes on August 1, up nearly 46% from a year earlier and at a five-year high.

Government wheat procurement during the 2026-27 marketing season reached about 35.76 million tonnes, exceeding the revised target of 34.6 million tonnes.

The move also comes as global wheat supplies face disruption. Attacks on Russian and Ukrainian grain infrastructure have disrupted Black Sea shipments, while Chicago wheat futures have risen more than 17% since early July, traders said.

The head of an international commodity trading association told HT that the decision was made possible because government wheat stocks are comfortable and there is no immediate food security concern. But he said exports remain difficult because Indian wheat is currently priced higher than global prices.

"At an exchange rate of ₹95.7 to the dollar, Black Sea wheat at about \$270 a tonne works out to roughly ₹2,580 per 100 kg before freight. Once freight to Southeast Asia is added, the price rises to about \$330-315 a tonne, or roughly ₹2,970-3,015 per 100 kg," he said. Indian wheat at Kandla—a major commercial port in Gujarat—would need to be around ₹2,600 per 100 kg for exporters to roughly break even. Right now, prices are hovering at about ₹2,700 per 100 kg, he said.

"It is at this price equation that earlier export quotas have not translated into anything close to the permitted volumes," the person citing above said, requesting anonymity.

Trade sources said actual exports so far have been very small, comprising only around 60,000 tonnes of wheat products, apart from small flows of wheat to Bangladesh.



Nirmala Sitharaman, Union finance minister.

FM TO TAKE PART IN INVESTMENT MEETINGS IN U.S. AND CANADA

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NEW DELHI: Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman will participate in investment roundtables in Canada and the US during her week-long sojourn in two North American countries from Tuesday and NASDAQ will host her in a bell-ringing ceremony.

The finance minister will visit Canada first, from August 25, with a focus on strengthening bilateral economic and financial partnerships, deepening investment linkages and advancing cooperation on shared global economic priorities, the finance ministry said in a statement on Monday. During her visit to Toronto, Sitharaman will participate in the inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue with the Canadian counterpart François-Philippe Champagne. "The dialogue will provide an important platform for both sides to exchange views on macroeconomic developments, financial sector cooperation and bilateral investment opportunities," the statement added.

"Bilateral discussions [between the two countries] in recent months have also focused on opportunities in areas including energy, critical minerals, technology, innovation and resilient supply chains, alongside ongoing efforts towards a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)," it said.

The finance minister will participate in an investment roundtable with leading CEOs, presidents and senior representatives, many from companies in the energy, artificial intelligence and critical minerals sectors, the statement said.

TCS to acquire Porsche's IT unit for ₹3,574 crore

NEW DELHI: Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) on Monday said it will acquire a 100% stake in MHP Management and IT-Beratung GmbH (MHP), a subsidiary of Porsche AG, for an enterprise value of ₹320 million (approximately ₹3,574 crore).

The acquisition is part of a broader five-year strategic partnership valued at ₹1.25 billion between TCS and the German sports car maker.

In a regulatory filing, TCS stated that the acquisition would be executed through its

wholly owned subsidiary, Tata Consultancy Services Netherlands BV.

"The Board of Directors of Tata Consultancy Services Netherlands BV, a wholly owned subsidiary of the Company, at its meeting held today, considered and approved the acquisition of 100% of equity shares of MHP Management and IT-Beratung GmbH ("MHP"), subsidiary of Porsche AG ("Porsche"), for an enterprise value of ₹320 million," TCS said in a regulatory filing.

UPI turns 10, transaction volume rises 13,000 fold

Press Trust of India

feedback@pvti.com

NEW DELHI: The Unified Payments Interface (UPI), which was launched on August 25, 2016, has completed a decade of transforming India's digital payments landscape, emerging as the backbone of the country's digital payments ecosystem and a global benchmark for real-time payments.

Annual UPI transaction volume rose from 1.78 crore in 2016-17 to more than 24,862 crore in 2025-26, an almost 13,000-fold increase, the finance ministry

said in a statement.

During the same period, transaction value jumped from ₹0.07 lakh crore to around ₹314 lakh crore, representing a more than 4,000-fold rise, it said.

Developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) under the regulatory oversight of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), UPI has recorded an unprecedented expansion in both transaction volume and value over the past 10 years, it said.

The year 2026 marked a significant milestone in the growth trajectory of UPI, it said, adding that monthly transaction



UPI emerged as a key pillar of India's digital public infra.

volumes crossed 2,300 crore for the first time in May 2026, reaching 2,300 crore transactions, signalling a new scale of adoption.

This momentum continued through the year, with July 2026 recording 2,966 crore transactions, the highest monthly transaction volume in UPI's decade-long journey, it said. UPI has witnessed a steady and broad-based expansion in institutional participation since its launch.

The number of banks live on UPI increased from 44 banks in 2016-17, the first year of operations, to 703 banks by 2025-26. In FY26, it said, UPI transactions totalling 24,162 crore reflected the platform's deep integration into everyday digital payment usage across the coun-

try, with robust momentum in the merchant segment.

The statement noted that the UPI has emerged as a key pillar of India's digital public infrastructure, providing an interoperable, real-time platform for seamless peer-to-peer and peer-to-merchant payments through a single interface. The platform has expanded access to digital financial services, helped bridge the digital divide and strengthened financial inclusion by enabling individuals, businesses and merchants across the country to participate in the formal digital economy, it said.

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CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

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SEBI REJECTS ADANI-LINKED OFFSHORE FUNDS' REQUESTS TO SETTLE CASES

Reuters

feedback@reuters.com

MUMBAI: The markets regulator rejected applications last week from at least three Mauritius-based funds with investments in the Adani Group to settle cases of regulatory violation involving failure to disclose their shareholder details, two sources with direct knowledge of the matter said.

Thirteen of the Adani Group's offshore investors have been facing an investigation by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) since Hindenburg research in 2023 alleged improper use of tax havens by the group, prompting a stock sell-off. The group has repeatedly denied wrongdoing, and its shares have since recovered.

Indian regulators require that at least 25% of a listed company's shares be held by public shareholders, but Hindenburg alleged the Adani Group breached those rules since some offshore funds with Adani company holdings were related to the conglomerate.

Last year, SEBI found two of the 13 offshore funds breached its rules when they failed to disclose their acquisitions of certain Adani stocks exceeding 5%—as was required by Indian regulations—and for impeding investigations.

SEBI last week rejected the applications of at least three more of the investors after they disagreed with the regulator over the monetary fine SEBI sought as part of a settlement, the two sources said. Reuters could not ascertain the names of the funds.

SEBI did not immediately respond to an emailed Reuters request for comment.

As part of the proposed settlement, the regulator sought details of the funds' shareholders, a condition the offshore investors opposed, one of the sources said. A settlement would have allowed the funds to resolve the proceedings without admitting or denying the regulator's findings. The cases could now proceed through SEBI's enforcement process including disclosure of regulatory findings, licence suspension in India and monetary penalties.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

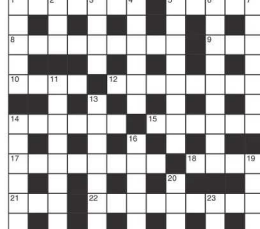
- 1 A vat containing nothing but chickens (7)
- 5 The capital gets poor return in this company (5)
- 8 Slow shuffling team means inevitable defeat (9)
- 9 Note the old-fashioned watch (3)
- 10 Boss is upset and shows distress (4)
- 12 Steps in dances (8)
- 14 Traces wrongly directed supplies (6)
- 15 Short-service commission (6)
- 17 Activity that makes open time (8)
- 18 So it is held by most husbands (4)
- 21 Sign of nerves in a critical situation (3)
- 22 Decorate the bride more ecotically (9)
- 24 He's put in little work yet has expectations (5)
- 25 Discard caricature (A,3)

DOWN

- 1 Cares about competitors (5)
- 2 Scandalous coin or note (3)
- 3 Capture and shoot (4)
- 4 It has the edge in rural gatherings (6)
- 5 New rate certain for water (8)
- 6 Go too far across a stretch of water (9)
- 7 Forced into service when one was short of time (7)
- 11 Floral trophy at the Dairy Show (9)
- 13 Squanders food (8)
- 14 The ache is placed in naturally spotted (7)
- 15 Doctor in habit of fighting (6)
- 17 Shoots up with an addition to a letter (5)
- 20 Cheat on the boards (4)
- 23 An act of duplicity (3)

PUZZLE 17573

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1 Bore a hole in (5)
- 5 Find no takers (2,7)
- 9 Small attached label (3)
- 10 Basic source (4)
- 12 Ship's cargo list (8)
- 14 Scientific study of plants (6)
- 15 Restore to good condition (6)
- 17 Laying (8)
- 18 Look over carefully (4)
- 21 Small spot (3)
- 22 With great enmity (2,1,3,3)
- 24 Young dog (5)
- 25 Case for the accused (7)

DOWN

- 1 Disorderly crowd (3)
- 3 Advantage (4)
- 4 Coloured (7)
- 5 Utterly weary (3-5)
- 6 Lacking information (2,3,4)
- 7 A shellfish (7)
- 11 At odds (3,2,4)
- 12 Extreme wickedness (8)
- 14 Increase gradually (5,2)
- 15 Unfounded rumour (6)
- 19 Perchance (5)
- 20 Sharp blow (4)
- 23 Unpleasantly pale (3)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17572)



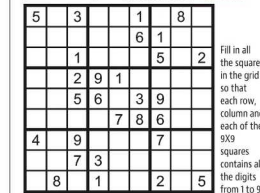
{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE - HIGH - LOW

TUESDAY	WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY
Generally cloudy sky with light rain	Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle	Generally cloudy sky
29°C 21°C	29°C 21°C	28°C 22°C

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL: ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

ALMANAC

Today is 25th August 2026
1 Rabi Ujja (Aash, 1448)
Purnima
Sunset: Sunday
Moonset: Sunday
Moonrise: Monday
Moonset: Monday

TEMPERATURE IN METRO

City	Temp
Delhi	35°C 26°C
Mumbai	32°C 28°C
Kolkata	32°C 28°C
Chennai	31°C 28°C
Bengaluru	29°C 21°C

Uninspired India go down to Argentina

The 3-5 defeat means Harmanpreet and Co are out of contention for a top four slot in the FIH World Cup

Shahid Judge

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MUMBAI: At the beginning, there was hope. They needed to win by at least two goals. And there was a stirring pep talk by captain Harmanpreet Singh in the team huddle. "We can do this!" The captain exclaimed again and again. But what started with a war cry ended in a whimper.

At the Wagener Stadium in Amstelveen, with a potential spot in the Men's Hockey World Cup semi-final on the line, India were outplayed 3-5 by Argentina.

India had not won a World Cup title since their lone triumph in 1975. The challenge to end that 51-year wait saw the world No.8 team fail to win any of the three matches against higher-ranked opponents — losing to No.4 England, No.1 Netherlands, and No.7 Argentina.

Alarmingly though, there were defensive frailties on display throughout. India conceded 16 goals across the five matches played so far (the consolation classification match will be played on Friday). Of those, 12 were field goals. India scored five field goals from their 14 in total.

On Monday, those defensive lapses came to the fore in as early as 39 seconds. Argentina came off the blocks quickly. Tomas Domene carried the ball into the shooting circle from the right flank and played a square pass across the goal. The unmarked Joaquin Toscani, stationed near the far post, collected and slotted past HS Mohith in the Indian goal.



Action during India's World Cup match against Argentina.

FH

Five minutes later, another defensive mix-up saw Harmanpreet let go of a long pass into the box, only for Sumit to get caught with the ball by Nicolas della Torre in a moment of indecision for a penalty corner for Argentina. Della Torre himself stepped up to power it home to double the lead.

By the 10th minute, hope returned for the Indian cause after Sukhjeter Singh hammered a shot from close range on the swivel to pull one back, as India went into the half-time break trailing 1-2.

The end-to-end play from the first half continued after the restart, with Argentina once again making threatening forays towards the India goal. Los Leones didn't have to wait long to find the back of the net. Lucas Toscani drove into the circle. A tackle took the ball away from him, only for it

to fall invitingly to Domene, who slotted home first-time with a reverse hit.

Domene scored again in the last minute of the third quarter after yet another defensive howler.

Yashdeep Sivach attempted a low crossfield pass in his own half, but it was intercepted by an Argentine attacker. As the shot on target came in, the ball crashed into Sivach's leg for a penalty stroke that Domene converted without much fuss for his eighth goal of the tournament — the highest scorer for the competition so far.

Lucas Toscani then got onto the scoresheet in the 53rd minute after some clever link-up play with Martin Ferreiro to take the game well beyond India's reach. Leading by four goals though,

Argentina's intensity dropped in the final few minutes which allowed India to make a few late charges towards goal.

Sukhjeter got his second goal of the match after a clever deflection from a pass Manddeep Singh smashed into the circle. And then in the final minute of play, Hardik Singh converted a penalty stroke to reduce the deficit to two.

"For us, our defence was not so good," Hardik said after the match. "We wanted to play the game normally and the goal would come. It just didn't happen as we planned."

With a top four slot out of contention, India will play their last match of the tournament against Belgium in the seventh place match on Friday.

Indeed, nothing quite went according to plan.

Women's WC: How India exceeded expectations

Sandip Sikdar

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NEW DELHI: It was a team that had seemingly lost its way. Having failed to qualify for the 2024 Paris Olympics, relegated from the FIH Pro League, and bogged down by internal tensions and rifts over the last couple of years, the Indian women's hockey team arrived at the World Cup in the Netherlands and Belgium with more questions than answers.

They hadn't played a top-tier team in a year. Yet, against all odds, they delivered a performance that has reignited hope and proved they can still go toe-to-toe with the sport's powerhouses.

Returning to the setup in January, after previously guiding the team to a historic fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021, chief coach Sjerd Marjine engineered a stunning turnaround. Within months, he helped the squad qualify for the World Cup and secured the Nations Cup title that earned them a ticket back to the elite Pro League.

At the World Cup itself, the team showcased a newfound resilience, finishing the tournament with one win, one loss, and three draws in five matches. Those three draws were not against pushovers, but against true hockey pedigree. Savita Punia and Bichu Devi Kharibam were sensational under the bar, absorbing relentless pressure. But defensive resilience in modern hockey isn't just about stick-work, it is driven by elite physical conditioning.

That is where Wayne Lombard, the team's head of athletic performance, played a transformative role. Moving away from a traditional "one-size-fits-all" conditioning model, the South African and his sports science team utilised advanced data analytics and GPS trackers to individualise training. "My assessment from afar: simple game plan and role clarity for players," 1980 Olympic champion MM Somaya, who is also a national selector, told HT.

"Players can defend in numbers



India held Australia to a 0-0 draw on Sunday.

APF

we much higher ranked was nothing less than commendable," former India captain Mamta Kharab told HT. "We could have won against Australia but could not convert our chances. Even against the Netherlands, we put up a solid fight. Don't forget, many of these girls are playing the World Cup for the first time," added the 44-year-old.

Much of this success was built on the foundation of a rock-solid defence and brilliant goalkeeping. Savita Punia and Bichu Devi Kharibam were sensational under the bar, absorbing relentless pressure. But defensive resilience in modern hockey isn't just about stick-work, it is driven by elite physical conditioning.

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and transition into attack quickly due to high fitness levels. For this, Sjerd's strengthening and conditioning team led by Wayne Lombard played an important role. Also, he wins the players' trust by allowing them personal space."

But as former India women's coach Neil Hawgood pointed out, the puzzle is not yet complete. While praising Marjine's rapid turnaround, Hawgood noted the absence of a quintessential match-winner.

"Last night's game, they were missing a game breaker, which is something they have had for the last 14 years; they had someone who could break the game apart," Hawgood, who helped India qualify for the Olympics after 36 years at Rio 2016, told HT. "Where are Rani (Rampal), Jaspreet (Kaur), Vandana (Kataria), who score goals? They should have won last night's game."

The LA 2028 ticket is now the ultimate prize. Having finished above the Alyson Annan-coached Chinese side at the World Cup, the dynamics in Asian hockey have noticeably spiced up. The 2-2 draw has brought a renewed belief that India can not only compete with but conquer their neighbours at the Asian Games.

DPL: DOBAL POWERS SOUTH DELHI SUPERSTARZ TO EASY VICTORY

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: South Delhi Superstarz rode on opener Anmol Sharma's 57 (3X4, 3X6) and some late power hitting from Ekansh Dobal (38 off 18, 2X4, 4X6) and Ankit Dabas (18 off 5; 3X6) to escape with a five-wicket win over bottom-placed New Delhi in the rain-delayed Delhi Premier League (DPL) encounter at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Monday.

Chasing 169, Superstarz, having already qualified for the playoffs, looked done and dusted until the 18th over when Dobal and Dabas unfurled their range hitting. In the end, Superstarz reached the target with nine balls to spare.

Earlier, Lakshay Thareja's 47-ball 62 (2X4, 4X6) powered Tigers to a competitive 168/9 in their 20 overs.

Batting first after skipper Himmat Singh called correctly at the toss, Keshav Dalal Singh and Hritik Shokeen gave Tigers a breezy but brief start before Vivek Tiwari sent Keshav back with 24 runs on the board. Tigers were jolted again just two runs and three balls later when Hritik fell to Pranshu Vijayan. Skipper Himmat (24 runs; 1X4, 2X6) then steadied the ship with a 46-run alliance with Lakshay but the late impetus never arrived. Pacer Divansh Rawat was taken for 25 runs in his two overs but cleaned up the tail to return with four wickets as Tigers folded for what proved to be an under-par total.



Divansh Rawat.

DOCA

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Jurel's unbeaten century puts India in command

Keeper's 115* helps India declare at 503/9 before reducing Sri Lanka to 8/2 at stumps on Day 2

Sanjeev K Samyal
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MUMBAI: With India resuming at 300/5, the game was still very much in the balance at the start of the second day's play in the second Test at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground on Monday. There was also doubt over Rishabh Pant's fitness after fast bowler Lahiru Kumara had struck him on the wrist overnight.

Sri Lanka could sense the visitors were vulnerable, and a couple of early breakthroughs would help them cut through the lower order.

Dhruv Jurel and Pant, however, rose to the occasion admirably, successfully thwarting the home team's spirited bid and taking India to a position of strength with a thrilling 112-run seventh-wicket partnership. Powered by Jurel's flawless unbeaten 117 (94, 266) and Pant's enterprising 63 (68, 266), India declared their first innings on 503/9 late in the post-tea session.

In the rain-interrupted final session, Sri Lanka made a disastrous start, losing opener Lahiru Udara (1) and nightwatchman Prathap Jayasuriya (2) inside three overs to end Day 2 on 8/2.

Pant held centre stage in the morning session for his courageous act of coming out to bat with an injured wrist, but in the final analysis Jurel made the difference by batting long.

In an innings where India conceded some soft wickets, Jurel dug in to ensure his team built on No.3 Devdutt Padikal's century for an imposing total.

Batting with controlled aggression, he hardly put a foot wrong throughout his long vigil at the crease, proving his credentials for the specialist batter's position at No.6. Jurel had come in at No.7.

Apart from his solid batting in the morning, he impressively defended the tail after Pant's exit, he frustrated Sri Lanka by forging useful partnerships with Manav Suthar (39 runs for the 8th wicket) and Mohammed Siraj (27 for the 9th) to ensure India didn't leave any runs out there.

The only time Jurel lost his composure was while searching for the single to complete his second Test century. He was stuck on 99 for more than three overs.

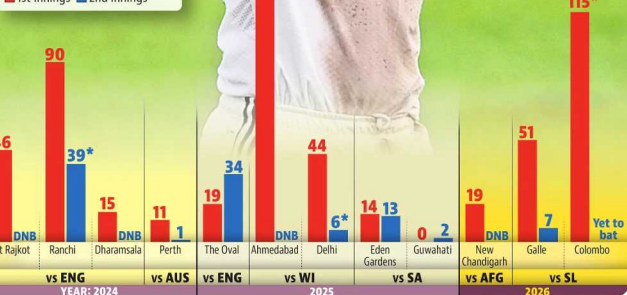
That anxiety saw him go for a risky single after hitting Asitha Fernando straight to the mid-off. A direct hit would have sent him packing. When the fielder missed, the celebration was one of relief and joy.

At the end of play, the focus was on whether Pant would be in a position to bat. It didn't take long to know. Pacer Asitha Fernando ensured the keeper-batter



Jurel in Tests

RUNS SCORED
■ 1st Innings ■ 2nd Innings



walked out to face the last ball of the day's second over after taking out debutant Surash Jain with a sharp bouncer.

The Sri Lanka bowlers were looking to spot any visible signs of discomfort Pant was showing while batting with the left hand. Predictably, the pacers started firing bouncers at him.

It was box office stuff. If he was in pain, Pant did well to hide it. He played with better balance and was more composed.

When Lahiru Kumara bounced him in the 90th over, Pant answered with a statement shot. He got into perfect position, lined it up and hooked it into the roof of the stadium.

It signalled the start of a thrilling partnership between the keeper-batter. India dominated the session, scoring 119 runs in an intense period of play.

Expectedly, Pant got further

targeted by Fernando and Kumara. The stocky left-hander put his body on the line, taking two painful blows to his right shoulder in the first hour of play, but soldiered on.

The pair batted against the situation but were a study in contrast. Pant lived on the edge, kept gritting it out, while Jurel stuck to the conventional game, putting a high price on his wicket.

While the pacers gave Pant a torrid time, Jurel handled them with confidence. He started the day with a crisp off-cut of Kumara, driving with the full face of the bat and straight through mid-on. Fernando had made life difficult for Pant with the short ball, but when he tried the tactics against Jurel, he pulled comfortably for four to bring up the 50 of the partnership in 10.2 overs.

The duo combined to take India to 419/6 at lunch, scoring at

more than four runs an over. Jurel was 59 not out (107b, 5x4) and Pant 63 (88b, 6x4, 2x6).

The ball was turning quite a bit for the spinners, but the Sri Lanka pair of Prathap Jayasuriya and Keshava Nuwantha couldn't build pressure consistently to put India under pressure. Jurel kept picking the gaps and Pant, unsettled the off-spinner, Nuwantha, who had a long spell from one end, with sweeps and reverse sweeps.

He smashed Jayasuriya for a four and six in the last over before lunch, but when he tried to go for a big hit first ball after the break against Nuwantha, he didn't get to the pitch of the ball and hauled out to long-off.

Though the partnership was broken, Jurel ensured India did not lose the momentum, leaving the hosts, who lost the first Test, under pressure.

SCORECARD

India 1st Innings (101.100/5)	
R Pant (Udara b Nuwantha)	63
D Jurel not out	115
S Jain c Mishra b Fernando	6
J Ajan c C de Silva b Jayasuriya	18
M Siraj lbw b Jayasuriya	3
P Krishna not out	4
Extras (8, lb 3, nb 3, w 2)	21
Total (for 9 wickets dec, 138 ov)	503
Fall: 6-107, 7-419, 8-458, 9-489	
Bowling: A Fernando 29-5-106-4, Kumara 20-4-68-1, Jayasuriya 42-7-132, Nuwantha 38-3-154-2, Dimutha 3-0-8-0, De Silva 2-0-54-2, Mishra 4-0-16-0	
Sri Lanka 1st Innings	
L Udara c Jaiswal b Padikal	1
K Mishra batting	5
Playasuriya lbw S Suthar	6
Extras	8
Total (for 3 overs)	8
Fall: 1-1, 2-8	
Bowling: Siraj 1-0-1-0, Prasad 1-0-1-1, Suthar 1-0-6-1	

Jaiswal, Fernando fined for confrontation on Day 1

HT Correspondent

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MUMBAI: India's opening batter Yashasvi Jaiswal and Sri Lanka pacer Asitha Fernando were fined 25% of their match fees for "inappropriate physical contact" during the first day's play in the second Test at Colombo's Sinhalese Sports Club Ground on Sunday.

Both players will also have a demerit point added to their disciplinary records based on the ruling of ICC match referee Andy Pycroft.

The incident occurred following Jaiswal's dismissal by Fernando in the 17th over of the India first innings. Jaiswal was walking back to the pavilion before angrily turning back to confront the bowler who dismissed him. It appeared to be a reaction to some remark made by Pycroft that offended the batter.

Jaiswal, still wearing his helmet, got into a near head butt with Fernando, who too wasn't in the mood to take a backward step before the duo were separated by the Sri Lankan fielders.

An ICC statement on Monday said that the players were found guilty of Level 4 offence, breaching Article 2.12 of the ICC Code of Conduct for Players and Player Support Personnel relating to "inappropriate physical contact" between a Player and Player Support Personnel, Umpire,



India's Yashasvi Jaiswal confronts Sri Lanka's Asitha Fernando after his dismissal during the first day of the second Test.

Match Referee or any other person (including a spectator during an International Match).

"Cricket being a non-contact sport, Jaiswal might have been penalised more harshly on another day. Pycroft's sanctions were accepted by both the players, ruling out the need for a formal hearing.

The demerit point was the first against both Jaiswal and Fernando over the last 24 months. An accumulation of four or more demerit points over a 24-month period results in a conversion to suspension points and a match ban.

The Indian team was also on the defensive over Jaiswal's behaviour. "I think the bowler com-

mented something and it happened in the heat of the moment. Obviously, Jaiswal shouldn't have gone so close to him, but it happened in the heat of the moment," Indian team assistant coach Sitanshu Kotak told the media on Sunday.

Former India captain, Kapil Dev, when asked about it, said in Delhi: "These things happen. You have to move on in life. Every player has his own character. If that's the way he wants to play, good luck to him. But as a cricket board, one has to see where they have to draw the line. The players should not cross that line. You are allowed to do whatever you want as long as you are not spilling the name of cricket."

PGTI announces rejigged calendar

Shantanu Srivastava

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NEW DELHI: The Professional Golf Tour of India (PGTI) on Monday announced a rejig of its domestic calendar to introduce the Road to DP World India Championship, making it the season-ending competition for Indian pros.

A set of nine tournaments will form part of the Race to DP World India Championship. They will serve to identify the top 24 players who will earn Argentinian 2-21-quarter-final victory.

The restructuring means the PGTI season will now run from November to October instead of being played through the calendar year. "This is done to ensure the PGTI Order of Merit leader

who gets to play on the DP World Tour (European Tour) doesn't miss out on the European events. Our top player needs to miss 4-5 events because our Order of Merit was only announced in December whereas the DP World Tour starts in November. So, this year because we would have crowned our (OOm) champion in October, he will get a chance to go to Europe at the start of their season," PGTI CEO Amandeep Johi said.

PGTI has modelled the new season, post the October instead of being played through the calendar year. "This is done to ensure the PGTI Order of Merit leader who gets to play on the DP World Tour (European Tour) doesn't miss out on the European events. Our top player needs to miss 4-5 events because our Order of Merit was only announced in December whereas the DP World Tour starts in November. So, this year because we would have crowned our (OOm) champion in October, he will get a chance to go to Europe at the start of their season," PGTI CEO Amandeep Johi said.

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ENGLAND DROP CARSE AMID NIGHTCLUB ROW

LONDON: England pacer Brydon Carse was dropped for the second Test against Pakistan following the latest off-field incident to affect the national side.

Images on social media showed Carse in handcuffs outside a nightclub in Derby on Saturday night, following a game with his club side Durham.

The Cricket Regulator will independently investigate the matter. Outcome can include no further action being taken, a caution or a charge for breaching regulations.

Pant shows he can play the percentages as well

Rasesh Mandani

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MUMBAI: When Rishabh Pant failed to find air or distance after holing out to long-off on the first ball after lunch on Day 2, the dismissal wasn't quite 'stupid, stupid, stupid' territory, but there were those who would find fault in the left-hander not kicking on to bat Sri Lanka out of the match after the gains from the first session.

Pant knows all about it. Sunil Gavaskar schooled him on air for his lack of game awareness during the 2024 Melbourne Test match. He had been reprimanded by head coach Gautam Gambhir after a reckless dismissal in last year's Guwahati Test against South Africa. Search for silver linings from Pant's 89-ball 63 at Colombo, and there's one quite easy to spot: the criticism hasn't got to him. He is still in the flow of his cricket. That's how he gets his laurels. About the bricks, he's learning to take them in his stride.

To those who were discomfited by Pant's dismissal on Monday, it had a lot to do with the batter taking the aggressive option too early after a 40-minute interval. That's not how anyone else plays Test cricket. One is told, Test cricket offers enough time to build and rebuild.

What Pant tries to do is break the mould. That's how he gets his runs by pulling off the unexpected against the opposition.

That's all he was trying when he attempted to lift Keshava Nuwantha over long-off early in the post-lunch session. It's exactly the kind of shot he had employed in the previous over. The last one before lunch off Prathap Jayasuriya and managed to clear long-on. Playing for lunch? There's no such word in Pant's lexicon.

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Pant shows he can play the percentages as well



Rishabh Pant plays a shot on Day 2 of the Colombo Test.

the left-arm spinner. Although he was still swinging with the bat, there was greater risk at play for the left-hander.

Pant would have taken mental notes but not because of the public rebukes. You can see he gets his runs by pulling off the unexpected against the opposition. That's all he was trying when he attempted to lift Keshava Nuwantha over long-off early in the post-lunch session. It's exactly the kind of shot he had employed in the previous over. The last one before lunch off Prathap Jayasuriya and managed to clear long-on. Playing for lunch? There's no such word in Pant's lexicon.

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that failing to execute a similar shot the previous week had left him bruised. While picking his moments to attack with care, when he sees an opportunity, he doesn't hold back.

Pant's whites are usually soiled. For he does not shy away from playing the falling sweeps, even if it is for a single. Simply because he has spotted a gap in the line while facing the left-arm spinner. That to Pant was a percentage stroke, just like strolling for a single to long-off.

Pant plays a high-risk game. And he's not always succeed. But he continues to remain an original. And the good thing is, his daring is still intact.

DULEEP TROPHY: ABID, ARSHDEEP GIVE NORTH SLIM LEAD ON DAY 2

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: Left-arm spinner Abid Mushtaq and Arshdeep Singh bowled beautifully to give North Zone a crucial first-innings lead of 64 against Tamil Nadu on the second day of the Duleep Trophy quarter-final.

Starting at 31/2 after North had scored 251 in their first essay, West battlers were below par as they were bowled out 181 with Mushtaq grabbing 5/39 in 25.5 overs and Arshdeep taking 3/53. Shams Mulani (52 of 94 balls) was the only batter who looked the part while Mushtaq Khan (31) was the other player who crossed the 30-run mark.

North were 107/4 at stumps.

East eye win
All-rounder Shabbaz Ahmed hit a career best first-class score of 167 and then got three wickets with his left-arm spin as East enforced follow-on on North East. East scored 467 and then bowled out North East for 111 with Tripathi pacer Abhishek Sarkar taking 5/20 and Shabbaz bagging 3/20. North East were 7/0 with another 35 runs needed to avoid innings defeat. **Brief scores:** North 251 & 107/4 (A Badoni 39.5, Mulani 2/34, T Kofan 2/72). West 187 (S Mulani 52). North East 31. A Mushtaq 5/39, A Kofan 3/53. **East 467 (S Ahmed 167, S Gharani 146, K Kishagra 55, S Singh 164). North East 107 (A Bhattacharya 32, A Sarkar 5/20, S Ahmed 3/20) 8/70.**

MEMORABILIA | 1986 FIFA WORLD CUP

Maradona's 'Hand of God' ball sells for \$3.3m

Agencies

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

LONDON: The football used by Diego Maradona to score his infamous 'Hand of God' goal against England at the 1986 World Cup has sold for \$2.25m (\$3.3m) at an auction.

Maradona used his hand to punch the ball past England goalkeeper Peter Shilton during Argentina's 2-1 quarter-final victory. After the match, he famously described the goal as being scored "a little with the head of Maradona and a little with the hand of God."

The same game also saw Mar-

adona score what would later be named the 'Goal of the Century'. He dribbled past five England outfield players before calmly finishing past Shilton.

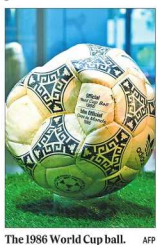
The Adidas Azteca ball sold for \$3.3m (\$2.5m) at Heritage Auctions in the United States on Saturday. However, it had been expected to sell for close to \$10m (£7.3m).

Before the auction, Heritage specialist Mike Provenza described the ball as a unique piece of football history, saying it was "arguably the most significant soccer item that exists."

The ball was collected at a

erree All Bin Nasser, who kept it for more than 30 years. In 2023, Bin Nasser signed a letter confirming that it was the only ball used during the match. Its authenticity was subsequently supported by independent experts.

Bin Nasser originally sold the ball in 2022 for \$2.37m (£1.74m). The new owner intended to auction it again in 2023, but the sale fell through after bids failed to reach the reserve price. The football is not the only famous item from the match to have attracted a huge price. Maradona's shirt from the England game sold at auction for £7.1m in 2022.



The 1986 World Cup ball.